

INDIGENOUS RELIGION

CONCEPT OF GOD

-The belief in the existence of God is prevalent among Traditionalists in many African societies including Zimbabwe.

-The Supreme Being “is no stranger and he looms large in the consciousness of the people.

-The notions of and beliefs about God as are expressed in his names, attributes, activities and through the worship

Discuss the concept of God {any five points}

1 All powerful

-God is the one to whom absolute power and might are attributed.

-The African God is “a God of Power..the ultimate source of all power”

-In many African Religions, the omnipotence of God has far-reaching implications.

-It is seen as the source and the basis upon which other attributes and activities of God are discussed.

-It is because of God’s omnipotence that he can be present everywhere; that he is all-knowing; all-seeing; and can carry out his activities as he chooses.

-God’s overriding power surpasses that of any being, natural or supernatural.

- God is who he is, and can do what he chooses because of his omnipotence.

-He is considered the ultimate cause of a person’s fortunes or misfortunes in life and death, the

determiner of the number of children born in a household and of all events.

-In that regard, ultimate responsibility for everything that happens from birth until death is attributed to God.

-However, this does not mean that God is held responsible for the perpetration of evil or for

unfortunate happenings it simply infers that God has allowed these situations to occur.

2 All present

-God is everywhere.

- He is he one whom you meet everywhere

-He is not only the "Preexisted One", but the one whose presence pervades the earth.

In general, the Traditionalists believe that God manifests himself to them during times of worship and religious gatherings.

-God's presence is strongly assumed at all major sacrifices.

-The omnipresence of God is also connected with natural occurrences such as thunder and lightning.

3 All knowing

- God has all wisdom and knowledge

and that even if we may know some things, it is only God who knows all.

-No one else, apart from God, is worthy of, or is given, the attribute of Omniscience.

-Often it is because of our imperfect and incomplete knowledge that we affirm God's omniscience.

-There is a common view in West Africa which may have originated from Nigeria that says: "No one knows tomorrow." You can make your plans ahead but from a human point of view you cannot tell exactly how things will turn out; in the final analysis only God knows.

4 All-Seeing

-God not only knows, he also sees, for nothing is hidden from him.

-G sees everything because he lives above.

-God sees whatever we do.

- This concept echoes the African belief that, "wrong-doers cannot escape the judgment of God".

5 Ruler

- The concept of God the Creator as the supreme ruler of the world is prevalent in Africa.
- In indigenous religion, the notion of sovereignty is of particular significance in the peoples' attitude towards God.

Among the religions in Africa, God's role as ruler is of course understood to be analogous to that of a chief.

-As a chief, God is always thought of as one with immense authority and wisdom, and as one who performs the functions of a judge, and maintains justice and equity.

-It is by the chief's authority that the people in his jurisdiction are able to carry on their day-to-day affairs or maintain their respective position.

-As such, the Traditionalists find it difficult to conceive of social life and maintain daily living without the chief.

You can consider Creator(musiki) Healer (murapi) etc

ANCESTRAL SPIRITS

- In most African cultures, the ancestors are of central importance in the lives of most indigenous traditionalists.

-To take the ancestors away from them is to destroy their roots in the past, their culture, their dignity and their understanding of communion sanctorum.

Categories of Ancestors

- Ancestors of a direct genealogy of a particular family or group of families.
- Ancestors who were community heroes whose memories have come down in history as the defenders of their community, and of their ethnic group.
- Ancestors associated with professional expertise ,smiths, hunters, and sacred specialists.

The Role/ Functions of the Ancestors

-The ancestors are closely involved in the life of the Traditionalists by manifesting interest in the welfare of the communities to which they belonged, and still belong.

- Not only do they belong to their respective communities, they also order the lives that are led there.

- Even though spatially they are primarily associated with their graves, because of their spiritual characteristic, they are capable of following their children wherever they go, which makes it possible to call on them everywhere and from anywhere in the world.
- Not only are they ever-present, they are also conversant with everything that goes on in the community.
- Although the dead are physically removed from them, the traditionalists believe that they continue to watch over and influence them.
- People bring their problems to the ancestors, and entreat them to intercede with God on their behalf, to bring good fortune and a better life to them, and so on.
- The Ancestors are intermediaries between the living and God (19, with characteristics similar to those of humankind, but with a superior power, and a supernatural ability to help the living.
- They speak to people in dreams and in strange events for instance, “if the first glass of wine was spilt.
- Prayers are relayed through the stream of Ancestors until they eventually reach God.
- They are addressed in idiomatic expressions of surprise, wonder, or in-ability to understand the happening.

CONCEPT OF MEDIUMSHIP

- There are five categories of medium in which the Shona believes.

1. The tribal Spirit (mhondoro).

- This is the spirit of the whole clan of the tribe.
- The Shona believes that these spirits brings rain and are responsible for the production of good crops.
- They are also responsible in giving the decision as to who shall succeed to the chieftainship.

2. Ancestral Spirits (Vadzimu).

- The ancestral spirits helps and protects the individual units of the clan.
- They could be the spirit of the mother, father, grandmother or grandfather.

3. The Alien Spirit.

- This could be the spirit of a foreigner who did not receive proper burial.
- The spirit needs to be remembered through prayer and ritual ceremonies.
- The talent in this spirit include hunting.

4. Traditional Healer (N'anga).

- This is a special spirit of healing.
- This type of spirit remains in the family when the original N'anga dies.
- It is regarded as a good spirit in ATR because of its role eg can consult the ancestors.

Method used by traditional healers.

1. Kupfungaidza
2. Use of herbs
3. Kutemera.
4. Use of Ushers
5. Use of mafuta Ehwei.
6. Kutsipika.

5. The evil spirit of the witch

- This maybe inherited from the great grandmother who was a witch.
- Whenever a woman rejects this spirit, she may encounter the problem of losing a child whenever she is pregnant.

Role of Mediums in the Liberation Struggle.

- Preparing and mobilizing people for war
- Inspiring people to fight eg Nehanda and Kaguvu
- Co-ordinating military strategy.
- Giving medicine to fighters.
- Healing the wounded.
- Seeking for foreign assistance.

- Providing food
- Providing logistics needed during the uprising.
- They co-ordinated the war.

TOTEMS AND INDIGENOUS IDENTITIES.

Defining Totem

-It is a spirit being, sacred object, or symbol that serves as an emblem of a group of people, such as family, clan, lineage or tribe.

- Can also be defined as any animal, plant or other object, natural or supernatural which provides deeply symbolic meaning for a person/ social group.

- Totemism is an aspect of religious belief centered upon the veneration of sacred objects called totems.

Importance of totems

- In traditional African culture, kinship is two-prolonged and can be established either by bloodline or totem.

-The concept of using totems demonstrates the close relationship between humans, animals and the lived environment.

- Totems are a source of family pride and are about identity.

- Totems have also been described as a traditional environment conservation method besides being kinship.

- Totems identifies the different clans.

-. Totems build up some relationships and allow intermarriage between people of diverse totems.

- Totems are important because they are used on specific occasions to respect each other.

BELIEFS IN LIFE AFTER DEATH.

- There are several myths/stories about the origin of death .
 - In these stories, God did not intend for humankind to die, he gave to different animals preventives of death to take humans, in each story the appointed animal did not get to humankind on time as result death came into the world.
 - Traditionalists consider death as inevitable.
 - It is the ultimate end of every created being.
 - Therefore, life must be spent wisely and respectfully.
 - Death is feared because it physically snatches a person from his/her community.
 - The deceased is deprived from a physical communal life and activity.
 - A death, it is generally believed that the spirit leaves the body and assumes a spirit existence, and the buried body decays in the grave.
- The “good dead” spirit continues to be good. Under this category fall the ancestors and those who did not perform heroic acts to attain ancestors hip but did lead a decent and praiseworthy life.
- The “bad dead” spirit is believed to become evil and may become a ghost and taunt the living.
 - For most Traditionalists, the grave appears to be , the seal of everything, even if a person survives and continues to exist in the next world.
 - In religions of Africa, life does not end with death, but continues in another realm.
 - Traditionalists believe that those who are dead are never gone but are the thickening shadow, wood that groans, and are in the fire that is drying ,forest and in the house.
 - Dead people are believed to be of help to the family and the community in times of trouble and can also cause trouble if certain rituals are not performed well.
- Rituals associated with the belief in life after death
- In indigenous religion, there are quite a number of rituals that were/are performed surrounding death.
 - Those rituals were to facilitate the passage of the dead person between this world and the next one.

Reincarnation

-It refers to the soul of a dead person being reborn in the body of another

Transmigration

-It refers to the changing of a person into an animal.

Ritual Purification

-It is done by most religions and serves as the main aspect of their beliefs.

-Africans believe that anyone or anything that came in contact with the dead is unclean.

KUROVA GUA CEREMONY/MAGADZIRO

{SETTLING THE DECEASED'S SPIRIT}

The ceremony is known by different names among the Shona sub-cultural groups e.g karanga-magadziro, kugadzira mudzimu, Zezuru-kurova guva (to beat the grave), korekore kutamba mudzimu, kutora mudzimu or bona.

-however, the ceremony generally is performed during the same season of the year to serve a common function.

-Some rites may differ here and there but the function of ritual is the same i.e. to invite the spirit of the deceased into the family.

-The ceremony is directly linked to the burial ceremony due to the fact that when the burial ceremony is being conducted it is done in anticipation of performing the kurova guva in the near future.

- It takes place a year after burial

-The Shona belief that the body will have to completely decompose .however, there are instances where it can take place immediately after burial.

-This would be due to some difficulties surrounding the condition of the deceased's spirit.

-When a person dies the Shona believe that the spirit of the deceased wanders in the wilderness awaiting the kurova guva ceremony.

-Post -burial period the spirit is considered dangerous and can be manipulated by evil spirits.

-Musha mutema- there is a dark cloud that wonders in the family.

-The ritual can also be held after more than one year in some cases after 30 to 40 years due to several factors.

1. In poor families this was mainly due to lack of livestock especially cattle or the scarcity of grain to brew beer and food to feed people at the ceremony.

2. Sometimes there were droughts which would force people to post pone the ceremony.

3. The person might have died in a distant place

4 rituals are performed according to spirituality hence they have to wait until the senior's kurova guva has been done.

5. Family conflicts in some of them held to do with the decease's wealth and widow.

6. In modern days the impact of western religious (Christianity)

-The ceremony was held during the dry season (August) dry season=religious and social activities.

It was seen after harvest that food will therefore be plentiful.

-There were certain taboos that were supposed to be respected between the burial and the kurova guva ceremony by the members of the family e.g. The children were not supposed to marry

-The spirit should be there to bless their marriages

-They also wanted to prevent shock to the incoming of new members in the family.

-You were not supposed to temper with the estate of the deceased since it will have to wait the inheritance ceremony which is held after the KUROVA GUYA ceremony and this might include the widow.

-the widow herself was not to marry or indulge in sexual relations until after the kurova guva and nhaka ceremony.

-if a widow or widower decided to marry before kurovaguva ceremony that's violation which referred to as 'kupisa Guva'

PROCEDURES TO BE TAKEN IN THE KUROVA GUVA CEREMONY

-The rituals differ from place to place and region to region.

- They consult a n'anga to find out the procedure they should take.

- Consulting a n'anga is done to make sure that the ritual will be performed in a way that is acceptable to the spirit.

-From this stage all the steps will be done with amultation with the deceased's spirit.

-the ritual should have the approval of the family spirits.

-if one wants to marry there should be consultation.

-Millet beer will be brewed by elderly woman who are beyond child bearing stage with no sexual relations(kupedza Ura)

-she will be helped by the small boys and girls (pre pubescent boys and girls)

-members of the family are advised not to have conflict when preparing for the ceremony.

-On the evening before the ceremony the beer is concentrated to the spirit of the deceased by the eldest member of the family.

-The concentration marks an all night celebration that involves singing and dancing in honour of the spirit.

-Music is important because it enables communities between the living and the dead person.

-The next morning involves rite of inviting the spirit from the grave.

-This rite varies from area to area

-In some areas they remove one or two stones and ---- of porridge and beer are poured on the front of the grave to invite the spirit.

- The elder member of the family who will be leading will speak to the deceaseds asking the spirit to accept the invitation to come home.
- after this the entourage return home to dance and feast
- sometimes the spirit is symbolizing brought home.
- For the Shangwe they tie a black cloth around the neck of a ———on the——before the ceremony and take the good outside-the homestead and appropriate functioning will address the spirit that they are bringing home and sacrificed the following day.
- Among the Shona people of North E. Zimbabwe a branch is cut from a ceremonial tree and the severed end is covered to avoid the spirit from escaping.
- The branch is dropped to the homestead making fragment rest to the rest the spirit.
- The spirit is cooled by pouring beer into a branch.
- The branch is tied to the wall of the house of the family head.
- Among the Korekore a pathway is made between the grave and the homestead to provide the spirit into a road to travel as it rejoins the family.
- among the — there is need to go to the grave early in the morning the spirit is invited by members of the family by pouring water on the back of a goat addressing the spirit of the deceased to come home.
- if the spirit accepts the invitation the goat would shake its body vigorously.
- The goat is slaughtered and the meat is roasted and eaten without salt.

SIGNIFICANCE OF THE CEREMONY

1. It brings hope and confidence into the family considering the unpredictability of the spirit of the deceased.
2. It marks the end of mourning in the homestead which is referred to as *musha mutema*

The widow will no longer veil her head with black cloth or wear the symbolic black dress of mourning - return to mourning.

3. It resolves problems and tensions caused by death by the spirit of the deceased among the family's spirit guardians. The living and the dead would have restrengthened their cowardice relationship.
4. It allows one of the most important rituals in Shona culture to take place i.e. inheritance ceremony "NHAKA"
5. the ceremony celebrates shona religious practices and communities and reunites the people to the fundamental tradition of their culture
6. it strengthens relationship - ties as both close and distant relatives converge at one place for a common purpose. So it reaffirms social ties.

CHANGE- the ceremony has been replaced by memorial service-Christianity.

The Inheritance Ceremony.

-Before the Kurova Guva ritual is conducted, it is customary among the Shona to distribute all the personal belongings of the deceases which had been sealed after the funeral.

-If the deceased is a woman, blankets, pots and plates are taken by those from her maternal home and if it's a man things including his wife or wives are inherited by those from his home.

- The wife or wives to be inherited have to pass through the Kudarikatsvimbo rite to prove that they did not commit ant act of adultery since their husband's death.

-The wife/wives may choose whom she/they want to inherit

-At times she/they may choose not to be inherited but may give the responsibility of looking after the family to his eldest son.

-In some cases she/they may choose to go and stay with her/their parents.

Ritual of owner.

- After a certain period of time, at most annually, the ritual of owner ritual is performed.
- It might be in the face of calamity usually a misfortune like complex illness or even death in the family.
- The ritual is known as beer of the ancestors (doro rana sekuru).
- The annual rite of owner is normally addressed to the deceased head of an extended family.

Ritual of appeasement.

- Angry spirits are the most formidable phenomenon in their religious experiences.
- They are known to attack harshly or suddenly leading to death in the family.
- In such cases, ancestral spirits would be known to have withdrawn their protection from the family.
- The avenging spirits (Ngozi) would be causing havoc in the family.
- In such cases, the diviner is consulted.
- The payment known as kuripa ngozi would be paid in form of money, cattle and at times wife (virgin girl).

Pre-Burial Rites-Rituals before Burials

- These rituals tend to differ from area to area, clan to clan.
- According to MFC Bourdion, most of these rites are common in most Shona people.

1. Kupeta Ritual

- This is found among the Shona beliefs.
- This is whereby someone who has persisted to be near his/her death is moved outside his/her homestead.
- The place could be of his/her son, son-in-law or some close relative away from children and others in the village.
- Very close people will be aware of his/her whereabouts and will be the only people to visit.

2. Kuridza Mhere (Chema).

- When a person dies every family member of the deceased is notified.
- It is believed that if the family member is not notified, he/she experiences mystical misfortune eg getting hit by a car, getting tired etc,

3. Kubata Maoko.

- People around the neighbourhood/community goes to the funeral to show their sympathy.
- They bring with them chema/token of sympathy.

4. Kugeza mufi/washing ritual.

- It is believed that the deceased has to be clean before embarking the journey.
- The person is washed to become clean.
- The nephew, niece (Muzukuru) of the deceased or the sahwire bathes them.

FAMILY RELATIONS

- It is within the family environment that an individual's physical, emotional and psychological development occurs.
- It is from our family that we learn unconditional love ,we understand right from wrong, and we gain empathy, respect and self-regulation.
- These qualities enable us to engage positively at school, at work and in society in general.
- The family environment in which children grow up has been considered a key predictor of their future outcomes.
- Stable functional families contribute to youth social empowerment by providing many of the factors that protect young people from engaging in risky sexual behaviour, drug use and abuse, delinquency, and other anti-social behaviour.
- Negative family experience, poor child-parent attachment; a chaotic, dysfunctional, abusive, neglectful, or impoverished family environment may directly or indirectly hamper youth's social and economic empowerment.
- Families contribute to the economic empowerment of their members by playing a "role of insurer of last resort, providing aid and solace when all else fails and preventing temporary setbacks from becoming permanent".
- In Africa, as in many other developing regions(see for example, the extended family is

a long established institution which provides its members with sophisticated social security system, an economic support to meet their basic needs for food, shelter, and clothing, and a wide circle of relatives on whom to fall back in times of crisis, unemployment, sickness, poverty, old age, and bereavement.

-The family's affective role of nurturing and supporting its individual members includes promoting and safeguarding the health of children as well as instilling moral and social values in them, with the overall goal being to ensure that the next generation is productive and socially responsible.

-Children's growing competence and development is largely influenced by family life and family relationships. Children's well-being continues to depend on the quality of family interactions.

-Children of today are growing up in a variety of households and different family systems. A number of these different families includes,

- child families
- Large families
- Single parent families
- Blended families Adoptive parent families
- Grandparent families

-Family type plays an integral role in children's development. Family theories outline the interactions which occur between family members.

1. Only child families

-Many couples are now choosing to have children who will never have any siblings.

- Literature suggests that these children are often viewed as being spoilt, selfish, lonely and maladjusted, however, research does not agree with this negative view.

-Only children appear to be bright and successful, self-confident, self-reliant,

resourceful and popular with other children.

- A major reason for this may be that only children have somewhat closer relationships with parents, who exert more pressure for mastery and accomplishment.
- Only children often have more pressure placed upon them by parents to excel in tasks and have often high expectations for school and sporting results placed upon them.
- Only children miss out on the growing and learning and forms of socialisation which comes with having siblings.
- Only children have the advantage of not having to fight for their parents attention and may have the opportunity of more one-on-one interactions.

2. Large families

- Children of large families obviously experience different conditions from those in smaller or one child families. Children in larger families have the advantage of having relationships with siblings.
- These relationships and interactions gives them the opportunity to have companionship, emotional support and assistance while they are growing up.
- Children in larger families often experience degrees of rivalry and may need to fight for parents attention.
- The positive interactions that occur between siblings contribute to perspective taking, moral maturity, and competence in relating to other children .

3. Single parent families

- The number of one-parent families have become more common in recent years.
- There are a number of varieties of one-parent families; those resulting from divorce, parents who never-married, as well as a widowed parent. In single parent families the other parent not living with the family may have little or no involvement in the child's life or may be highly involved.

Single divorced parent families

- The largest percentage of single-parent families are headed by divorced female parents.
- The assumption has been made that the trauma from divorce is likely to result in poorly socialised, cognitively deficient children who experience poor parent-child relationships.
- In many situations this may be the case but no relationship can be generalised.

Never-married single parent families

- It is believed that a cultural shift towards later marriage has contributed to a rise in never-married motherhood.
- It has been thought that children in these kinds of families are shielded from marital strife; children of never-married mothers show slightly better academic performance and emotional adjustments than do children of divorced or remarried mothers.
- But they do not do as well as children in first marriage families compared with children of two parent reared families.
- Although compared with children of two parent families, these children may experience less attention, difficulties in interactions with other children, a lack in school performance and behaviours associated with the lack of a male parental influence.

4. Blended families

- The blended family is one in which either parent brings with them children from a previous marriage
- For some children, this expanded family network is a positive turn of events that brings with it greater adult attention, but for most, it presents difficult adjustments.
- It is clear that there are many difficulties in accepting a step-parent into the family,

especially one who may have different child rearing practices, from which the child is used to.

- Research has found that children of remarriage are likely to experience difficulty in accepting the marriage.

- This extends from some children having to - deal with the loss of a primary parent to acceptance of a new one.

- Other feelings experienced may include divided loyalties, confusion in terms of belonging, confusion due to membership in two households and unreasonable expectations due to the whole adjustment process. But how well children adapt is related to the overall quality of family functioning.

5. Grandparent reared families

- The number of grandparents rearing grandchildren has increased over the past decade.

- Usually, grandparents step in because of substance abuse, emotional problems, or physical illness prevents the child's parents, most often the mother, from engaging in competent child rearing.

- This situation can cause a lot of emotional distress for both the child, adjusting to a new situation and for the grandparents who have been suddenly placed into a child-rearing situation.

- Children in this environment usually receive a lot of love and also experience the required parental guidance.

6. Extended Family

- The extended family structure consists of two or more adults who are related, either by blood or marriage, living in the same home.

- This family includes many relatives living together and working toward common goals,

such as raising the children and keeping up with the household duties.

-Many extended families include cousins, aunts or uncles and grandparents living together.

- This type of family structure may form due to financial difficulties or because older relatives are unable to care for themselves alone.

-Extended families are becoming increasingly common all over the world.

rites of passage

-It is a celebration of the passage which occurs when an individual leaves one group to enter another. It involves a significant change of status in society.

-From the ancient times, African societies have marked the transitions of the life cycle, from birth to death, with rites of passage.

- Ceremonies that mark the stages of life provide clear definition of society's expectations of the individual and they give him/her a sense of identity and belonging.

-The rites of passage provide the African with the foundation of his or her being identity that is sexual identity and the roles of gender identity.

-Males are prepared for their responsibilities in the community as men and females prepared for their responsibility in the nation as women with no confusion

-Rites of passage have three phases: separation, liminality, and incorporation.

1. Separation

-In the first phase, people withdraw from their current status and prepare to move from one place or status to another.

-The first phase (of separation) comprises symbolic behavior signifying the detachment of the individual or group from an earlier fixed point in the social structure.

-There is often a detachment or "cutting away" from the former self in this phase, which is signified in symbolic actions and rituals.

2. Liminality

- The transition (liminal) phase is the period between states, during which one has left one place or state but has not yet entered or joined the next.
- The attributes of liminality or of liminal threshold people are necessarily ambiguous.

3. Incorporation

- In the third phase (reaggregation or incorporation), the passage is consummated by the ritual subject.
- Having completed the rite and assumed their new identity, one re-enters society with one's new status.
- Re-incorporation is characterized by elaborate rituals and ceremonies, like debutant balls and college graduation, and by outward symbols of new ties: thus, in rites of incorporation there is widespread use of the 'sacred bond', the 'sacred cord', the knot, and of analogous forms such as the belt, the ring, the bracelet and the crown.

Initiation.

- Among rites of passage, initiation was of particular importance.
- The process and details of initiation differ among societies.
- As they enter the adult world during their teenage years, African youngsters undergo a variety of initiation rituals.
- These rites provide individuals with instructions about what will be expected of them during the next phase of their lives.
- Due to initiation, one became an adult in the society and was given new tasks to fulfill on behalf of the community.
- In all initiation ceremonies, a select group of elders takes charge of the sequence of ritual events.
- To begin their training, initiates often enter a special place, a sacred forest or a ritually

built house.

- It is there that they lose their childhood identities and gain their adult selves.
- After the period of instruction, the initiates undergo an encounter or ordeal that marks the climax of their initiation and the beginning of their new lives.
- One would marry, perpetuate life through procreation and as a consequence of hope to be an ancestor and to be named after.

MARRIAGE INSTITUTION

- Marriage is referred to as a socially or ritually recognised union between spouses that establishes rights and obligations between them, between them and their children and between them and their in-laws.
- In most African cultures, marriages are believed to come from God.
- In the Traditionalist worldview, it is believed that God makes marriages, whether prearranged or otherwise, happen.
- Because God created marriage, and directs people to their rightful partners, it is believed that he is also the one who sustains marriages.
- Thus, at all weddings God is entreated for his blessing, and for the creation of a peaceful and stable home.
- In indigenous religion, marriage enhances harmony in the society because it involves not only the living but also the spiritual beings, especially the ancestors.

Types of Marriages.

- The type and function of marriage vary from culture to culture, and can change over time.
- In general they are two types of marriages which are the civil and religious.

1. Polygamy in Zimbabwe

- It involves marriage with more than one wife.
- Polygamy is widely accepted among different societies worldwide.
- This type of marriage has been present in the whole history of Africa like no other continent in the world.
- One of the reasons why this has happened is because the African societies have managed to see that children were a form of wealth and this way a family with more children was considered to be more powerful.
- Polygamy in Africa was considered to be part of the way one could build an empire.
- Only after the colonial era in Africa, polygamy has started to be perceived as a taboo.

2. Monogamy.

- In the Christian society, a “one man-one woman” model for the Christian marriage is advocated for.
- For the past several years, Christianity has continued to insist on monogamy as essential of marriage

DIVORCE IN INDIGENOUS RELIGION

- The rate of divorce has increased significantly especially during the past several decades globally and particularly in Africa.
- Divorce results in crisis for family members.
- For adults, divorce signifies the loss of an intimate relationship that also brought security and support.
- It also signifies a loss of hopes and dreams as well as feelings of failure.
- Although there may be relief over the divorce, being alone also brings fear, anxiety, loneliness, and guilt, especially if there are children involved.
- The rampant occurrence of divorce in African homes is found to have socio-economic and political effect in the society.
- Discouraging socio cultural factors and/or conditions that influence divorce and/or separation have long been matters of concern to spouses in Africa.

- Divorce affects the overall development of women.
- For instance, a divorced woman suffers discrimination because she is neither accepted in her matrimonial nor maternal home.
- However, some actions against divorced women are done in order to humiliate them for bringing shame and dishonour to their maternal families.
- indigenous marriage institutions reflect the knowledge, experiences and level of development of the local people.
- Each society has its own peculiar actions and/or behaviour that signal divorce.
- Infidelity, infertility, laziness and unhygienic behaviour are some of the major causes of divorce in many African societies and women with these attributes are usually returned to their parents.
- In Africa, it is believed that the value attached to children, barrenness is often considered an important cause of marriage instability in many African populations.

ROLE OF WOMEN IN INDIGENOUS RELIGION

- At the core of most indigenous religions is a deep respect for the earth which is expressed in rituals and practices that foster sustainability.
- Nature is often regarded as a sacred entity that comprises of all the people and beings of the earth.
- A holistic vision of the community and the endeavor of maintaining and transmitting these rituals and practices is commonly entrusted to female religious specialists.
- Women are referred to as anomalous creatures, intimately associated with the well-being of society through their life-giving attributes.
- Traditional African religious ideology, therefore, stresses the domestic orientation of women's lives, affirming their reproductive role while distaining other aspects of their sexuality.
- In African societies, the central communal cults may be addressed to a diverse array of spiritual beings which are royal ancestral spirits, deities, heroes or fertility spirits.

- In African societies, females frequently have important roles in personal rituals of status transformation associated with birth, puberty and death.
- From the perspective of women's ritual and secular roles, the most important status transforming rituals are concerned with the transformation of a girl into a nubile maiden.
- Such rituals occur in many African societies and whenever they occur, the principal officiants and participants are women.
- The symbolism of these rituals vividly portrays the essential cultural meaning of mature womanhood.
- Both religious ideology and female puberty rituals stresses the concepts associated with fertility and feminine sexuality.
- Fertility and vitality of humanity and its world represent important religious goals.
- Such goals reaffirm women's domestic and inferior orientations in society.

Concept of Unhu/Ubuntu

Define Unhu

It is the processual mental and physical dispositions of an individual characterised by humility, kindness, courtesy, warmth, empathy, understanding, respectfulness, friendliness, responsibility and consideration which manifest itself amongst others, in the manner one talks, walks, behaves, dresses and interacts with relatives and non-relatives alike.

-The Shona believe that there is an impersonal, omnipotent or principal Creator, called Muwari, Musikavanhu, or a Spirit which creates good and bad

Importance of exercising Unhu

- I. It expresses the African dignity, humanity, reciprocity and shared relations found in the African culture.
- II. It builds a solid culture in which communities view justice and solidarity as

fundamental for their survival.

- III. It supports the view that people do not live in isolation.
- IV. It produces positive Africans.
- V. It helps Africans to be united
- VI. It produces a well cultured citizen who grows responsibly
- VII. It promotes oneness in Africa.

Attributes of Unhu

- a) Compassion
- b) Reciprocity
- c) Dignity
- d) Humanity
- e) Mutual Interest
- f) Oneness
- g) Tolerance
- h) Respect
- i) Integrity
- j) Humility

Norms and Values

What are Norms?

-These are informal standards of behaviour which are formed as a result of relations.

What are values?

-These are standards and statements which address the most outstanding issues so that the objectives of the organisation can be achieved.

-Values are meant to bring success.

Examples of school norms and values

-The school's positive climate is anchored in its school norms.

-These norms includes respect, responsibility and rigor

1. Trust
2. Sharing
3. Respect
4. Responsibility

Importance of norms and values at schools

1. Human values form the basis of character and personality
2. The helps children to know the difference between right and wrong.
3. Enable children to be responsible of their actions.
4. Enables children to make good choices of friends
5. Enables children to live truthfully
6. Enables children to be disciplined all the time.

Norms and values at home

1. Respect

-These helps to guide behaviour at home as well as ensuring the success of the family

-At home, children are taught to respect elders including brothers, sisters, parents, relatives and neighbours

2. Courtesy

-At home children are taught to be polite and have a positive attitude

- Children are taught not be ill-mannered and rude.

3. Discipline

-Children are taught to be well disciplined that is obeying rules and regulations.

4. Honesty

-At home, children are taught and expected to be honest with themselves and others.

-They are taught not to steal.

Norms and values at the workplace

-They are important as they ensure the continued survival of the organisation.

1. Team Work

-Members of the organisation should work as a team.

-For organisational goals to be achieved there is need for members' combined effort.

2. Accountability.

-Members of the organisation should do their duties well and be answerable for their actions.

3. Punctuality.

- Employees need to be conscious about time.
- They should come to work early and knock off at the expected time.

4. Respect

- Everyone in the organisation needs to observe hierarchy and authority in order to effectively issue orders.
- For the organisational goals to be effectively achieved there is need for subordinates to follow their senior's orders and respect them.

5. Transparency

- Employees should allow inspection of their actions at any given period.

6. Productivity

- A sense of productivity should ring a bell in everyone's mind.
- Without productivity, the organisation is hopeless.

Indigenous Religion and Environment

- In the contemporary African world, there is a dichotomy between what is secular and what is religious.
- People's view of the universe has changed.
- The world is no longer viewed in the religious sense but rather it is looked at as something to be totally exploited for the benefit of the human being.
- Nature now is viewed in terms of exploitation of natural resources.
- Africans in the contemporary time should borrow a leaf from traditional Africa.
- They should use African cultural heritage in preservation and rehabilitation of the environment that has been destroyed and degraded by selfish economic motives of few people.

- In traditional African societies, many people believed that trees and forests were the manifestation of the power of the Supreme Being. They saw these things as ideal places to meet God.
- Traditional African societies had many shrines, which were associated with big trees such as fig trees and baobabs.
- These trees together with the vegetation around were preserved as sacred places for worship.
- Traditional trees, shrubs, grass and forests as valuable gifts from God.
- They respected big trees especially mūgumo (fig tree) as a place to meet God.
- Thus, sacrifices and offerings were done under the mūgumo tree.
- Until today, it is a taboo to cut a mūgumo tree because it is a sacred tree.
- The Africans did not attach much importance to trees and herbs just for spiritual purposes, but also because trees, herbs and plants in general were useful in enhancing human life.
- Apart from being symbols of God's presence among people, trees were seen as medicine to man and animals.
- Trees, leaves, roots and grasses provided herbal medicines to human beings and to wild as well as domestic animals.
- In order to preserve trees, shrubs, grass and vegetation in general, several strong taboos against cutting certain useful and sacred trees or destroying the vegetation were formulated.
- Safeguarding of the plants was a matter of concern.
- It was held that if one cut some of these trees, he or she might bleed to death.
- Therefore, because of the importance of trees, shrubs and vegetation, as having religious, physical, and cultural values, it was a moral obligation to preserve them in traditional African societies.

Land and water

- For traditional Africans, land and water were precious gifts from God the Creator.
- Africans have a strong connection with the land not only as an economic resource, but as a home, a place of sacrifice and offerings.
- When traditional African people struggled or fought for land, were not simply struggling or fighting for it economically but for social, moral and religious motives.
- Among Africans, “land is a sign of identity”.
- God gave it to the ancestors so that he may use it for his well-being and for the community’s well-being.
- That is why the placenta is buried into the soil to connect the new born with God and ancestors. Nobody is allowed to play with land.”
- As land was strongly connected to life, then traditional African people had moral responsibility to take care of it.
- Land bound people together in one community.
- Its absence threatened to tear them apart.
- This was because for many Africans, land was communal property.
- Land belonged to the community and God allotted it to the community through ancestors.
- Land was respected because it produced plants, which sustains human life.
- As a God given gift, Traditional Africans attached great value to land.
- It had religious significance and therefore sacred.

J UDAISM

ROLES OF PROPHETS

1. MESSENGERS OF YAHWEH

-The authority enjoyed by prophets among their people depended naturally on the fact that they were bearers of the divine word.

-They were commissioned by God and understood themselves as messengers of Yahweh hence they used the prophetic formula 'Thus says the Lord'.

-Thus they were primarily spokespersons for God to his people, denouncing them of their sins, pleading with them to repent to God, encouraging them to follow the will of God in all phases of their life..

-Israelite prophets were spokespersons for monotheistic Yahwism.

-Key features of Yahwism that formed the core of prophets are monotheistic, ethical and judgmental dimensions of Yahwism that stood at the center of the message of each of the ancient Israelite prophets.

-These three had no parallels in the ANE prophecy, i.e. they were essentially unique and made Israelite prophecy unique.

-The apodeitic law as exemplified in the Decalogue is the basis of monotheistic Yahwism.

'you shall have no other gods before me..' (Exodus 20:3).

-The apodeitic law is believed to be authentic to Israel.

-If prophets were spokespersons of monotheistic Yahwism, then basically they interpreted the apodictic laws that were at the centre of Yahwism which implies that the prophets spoke and represented that which was unique to Israel.

2. INTERCESSORS

-This is somebody who pleads on behalf of people to Yahweh, e.g. Gen 20:7, Amos 7:1-

6.

-The intercessory role is expressed in the tells of Elijah who helped one the widows of Zarephath to discover in her house oil and milk to keep herself and her son till the next good rains.

3. CULTIC FUNCTIONARIES

- Prophets were cultic office holders though we cannot deny that prophets were somehow linked to the cultic pattern.

-They were chief representatives of the heavenly council, divinely appointed to proclaim the word of God to the people.

-They sought no royal or ecclesiastical favours, since their lives were completely directed and decimated by the divine suzerain.

4. COVENANT MEDIATORS.

-Covenant involves a mutual agreement entered into by two individuals, or by two groups or an individual and a group.

-The effect was that peace prevailed between the two parties involved. In this case the covenant was between Yahweh and Israel.

-Here Yahweh was understood to be actively at work with Israel to guide his people in the path of truth and fidelity to the covenant.

-To maintain mutual understanding between these two parties, Yahweh elected the prophets as covenant mediators.

5. SOCIAL REFORMERS -CALLING FOR SOCIAL JUSTICE.

-Prophets were speaking on behalf of the less privileged in society and become the mouthpieces of those who had no power to stand for their rights.

-In times of ill-treatment and injustice such prophets stood for the ordinary people who

had no power to confront leaders and kings in society, for example Elijah and Naboth, Nathan and David.

- The poor were deprived of land and wealth, widows, the fatherless and the weak could not protect themselves.

- Prophets directed their messages to leaders or officials of institutions in society who had power and authority in the social life of Judah and Israel. (1 Kings 21, Amos 5:7-10, Isaiah 1:21-26.

- Issues of wealth, pursuit of it and possession of it were also addressed by prophets because they were sources of corruption.

- Amos' message- rich would build hewn stone houses, large vineyard e.t.c. the most vulnerable in society were oppressed like the widows and orphans- that was violation of justice.

Hence message of judgment to the Israelites was a result of injustice

6. ADJUDICATE INTER-TRIBAL DISPUTES

- Before the monarchy prophets would at tribal centres adjudicate inter-tribal disputes.

- So the designation of a leader of the tribes in time of danger, officiate at the ceremony of covenant. –

Above all things the leader was there to maintain the categorical law of the covenant in the life of the tribes.

7. POLITICAL ADVISORS

- When kingship was established in Israel much of the responsibility of the former covenant representatives was assumed by the king.

- However the king was not permitted to become the official spokesperson of the deity.

- Therefore prophecy was established to check and balance the powers of the kings.

- Prophets were involved in anointing and dethroning of kings.

- Whenever a king is enthroned and dethroned prophets are involved.
- Here prophets are seen to be playing a leading role in the formation of the kingdom. So at times prophets are regarded as revolutionaries.
- For religious and social changes to be fully addressed there was need to remove political leaders the argument being that religious and political practices which were a breach to the Sinai covenant were being promoted by the political leadership hence there was need to remove them to promote genuine reform back to the stipulations of the Sinai covenant.
- Thus it is not surprising to note that whenever a king is enthroned or dethroned, a prophet is being involved e.g. Elisha anointed Jehu while the Omrides were still in power and Jehu's revolution lead to some religious and political change.
- Whenever prophecy intervened in these matters, it was not for any other reason but for spiritual reasons.
- They were not against monarchical regime, against decline of Israelite law and custom, against encroachments of the magnets, against apostasy and against
- oppression of the humble class of Israel.
- In fact they were against the institution of the kings which were failing to adequately express loyalty to God.
- Politics and religion were interwoven and since prophets did not live in ivory tower separated from the lives of their society they were not puppets in the hands of an arbitrary deity.
- God used prophets as spokespersons without violating their own personalities hence they were not hollow tubes.
- So they reaffirm Yahweh's sovereign stay in the political sphere in which Israel lived.
- This made altogether a head on collision with the effect which was made to further Israel's political security especially with diplomacy and policy of military armament.

- At one point we find prophets giving oracles to attack showing harmonious co-operation between prophets and military leadership.
- Prophets near the Philistine Garrison in a clear indication that prophets were political.
- There are there to incite Israelites to engage in holy war against the Philistine enemy.

8. COURT OFFICIALS

- Prophets were consulted when great events were impending mostly before and during wars e.g. Ahab and Jehoshaphat tried to ensure victory over the Arameans at Gilead. Jehoshaphat wished to hear the word of Yahweh and summoned 400 prophets (1 Kings 22).
- Thus when entering upon important undertaking the king constantly applied to the prophets for the word from God e.g. David had Nathan as his court prophet, Rehoboam had Shemaiah, and Jeroboam had Ahijah.
- However it is not always the case that prophets were for the kings. Prophet's independence of the king might make him and sensor the king's action, e.g. Ahab hated Micaiah (1 Kings 22:8).

EARLIEST FORMS/MANIFESTATIONS OF PROPHECY IN ISRAEL

FORMS APPROVED IN THE BIBLE

1.DREAMS

- It is an event that is seen by an individual when he/she is asleep.
- God can visit a person in a dream and speak with him, for example the prophetic call of Samuel was made possible through dream (1 Samuel 3:1ff).
- In Deuteronomy 13:1ff 'if a prophet has arisen among you or a dreamer of dreams...' clearly points to the existence of this aspect in Ancient Israel.

- It should be noted that dreams received by non-Israelites needed a Hebrew interpreter, for example Joseph (Genesis 41:25-33) was called from prison to interpret Pharaoh's dream.

-Daniel also interpreted king Nebuchadnezzar's dream (Daniel 2:24-45).

2. LOTS (URIM AND THUMMIN)

-These were cast to detect a guilty person.

-In Joshua 7:14-19 Joshua discovered by lots the person who had offended God by taking spoils from the doomed city of Jericho.

-Achan was caught and was stoned to death in the valley of Achor.

-Lots were probably put in a basin and rapidly rotated.

-The answer was given by a lot which leapt first. this method was sometimes divinatory, e.g. the usage of sacred stones (urim and thummin) in the Old Testament.

-Urim and thummin were found inside an ephod. It seems according to 1 Samuel 2:18 and 2 Samuel 6:14, the ephod was some kind of a dress like an apron (as the word 'girded' may suggest).

-However in 1 Samuel 23:6,9 and 30:7 an ephod was some kind of symbolic vestment that was kept in a sanctuary and would be carried along by the priest or prophet during military expeditions.

-The urim and thummin were part of this vestment.

-The main purpose of this practice is to determine the will of the deity or deities on what course of action to take. The objects were religiously symbolic.

-Use of sacred stones is found in 1 Samuel 14:41-43. Saul used these stones to detect the guilty action of Jonathan.

-These objects can be compared to hakata (casting lots) in Zimbabwe.

-These objects need someone who is a religious official.

-The difference is that in Israel the ephod in which the lots are found was some kind of dress whereas in Zimbabwe lots are either bones or dried tree bucks or shells of snails or sea creatures or even stones.

-Just like hakata urim and thummin (two sides of part of an ephod that were marked differently) were used to determine or to manifest the divine will in terms of yes or no, this one and not that one.

-The symbolic nature and the fact that the ephod was kept at a sanctuary, it's most probable to have been a priestly object used to perform priestly duties.

-However determining and interpreting the will of God were usually prophetic functions. So lots in this case fall in the realm of a prophet.

3. VISION

-It is an appearance seen by an individual which is inaccessible to everybody else.

-The vision may be seen when one is in ecstasy.

-A person may see either symbol which are interpreted or real experience.

-Items that may appear in a vision may depend on the prophet's personal background, for example if Isaiah was originally a priest it is understandable that he experienced a vision in the temple.

-If Amos was a farmer, the imagery drawn in his vision involves pests.

-Visions are one of God's methods of divine revelation (Numbers 12:6)

4.ECSTASY

-According to B.W Anderson, ecstasy is an experience of being overcome with an emotion so powerful that self control or reason may be suspended.

-It does not arise from mere emotional rapture but from the spirit (ruah) of Yahweh which falls upon a person.

-It takes control of the self and makes one an instrument of divine will. In such a state unusual things happen, eg Elijah overtook the chariot of Ahab (1 Kings 18), Saul stripped off clothes and lay naked (1 Samuel 19:19-24).

-It transforms a prophet i.e made him another man (1 Samuel 10:6).

Judaism and Land

-Concerning sustainability of natural environments: this is an issue addressed by the Torah—but it is not just a Jewish issue, but an issue for all of humanity.

-The Torah teaches that the human being is meant to be a steward of planet Earth, “to work it and to protect it.” We are told that everything God created, “He saw that it was good.” “The world and all that is in it is God’s.” You can’t get a clearer message than that.

-The Bible provides environmental legislation.

-The Jewish nation in Israel felt an eternal bond to the Land of Israel, and therefore a responsibility to protect their environment.

-This serves as a precedent for humanity today, as we begin to realize that humanity as a whole has an eternal bond to the most beautiful planet we have yet to discover, planet Earth.

Some of the environmental legislation of the Torah:

1. A city must have a greenbelt surrounding it, thus limiting urban sprawl.
2. A fruit tree cannot be destroyed when setting siege to a city. Our tradition extended this to include any wanton destruction of nature that could be avoided.
3. The rabbis severely limited the grazing of goats and sheep in parts of Israel where they caused environmental damage. It is well known today that much of the desert in the Middle and Near East was caused by the grazing of these animals.
4. King Solomon appointed a minister to limit the harvesting of wood in the forests of Israel.
5. The Mishnah deals with laws of water and air pollution, limiting the rights of both rural and civic residents.

-Jewish tradition teaches us to care for our planet in order to preserve that which God has created.

-Psalm 24 notes, "The earth is the Lord's and the fullness thereof," a dramatic assertion of God's ownership of the land. I

-It follows, then, that any act that damages our earth is an offense against the property of God. The Jewish concept of *bal tashchit*, "do not destroy," forbids needless destruction.

-Judaism emphasizes our need to preserve our natural resources and generate new ones for future generations.

-The Torah (the Five Books of Moses) opens with a clear statement about God's relationship to the Earth - "In the beginning of God's creating the heavens and the earth..." The formation of the Earth is a matter of Divine concern, and therefore the preservation of that Earth must also be a matter of Divine concern.

-The relationship between God and the land is continuous and longer lasting than any relationship we may have with it.

-Thus in Leviticus God informs us that no land can be sold forever "for the land is Mine - you are but strangers resident with Me"

Judaism on Wealth and Poverty

- Judaism is generally supportive of the pursuit of wealth, as long as it is combined with generosity to the poor and less fortunate.
- The Book of Genesis relates how Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, and Joseph amassed and administered wealth.
- The Book of Proverbs seems to laud hard work and material productivity, and Job is rewarded by God for his travails with twice his original fortune.
- This positive valuation of material wealth should be read against other biblical verses which demonstrate a marked concern for the plight of the poor and other groups on the margins of society, including slaves, orphans, and widows.
- The condemnation of wealth pursued without concern for the good of the community and the wider society is a theme of rabbinic law (halakha).
- With the advance of industrialization and widespread poverty and social inequality in the nineteenth century, many Jewish intellectuals and labor leaders took up socialist ideas.
- Today, Jewish charities are active inside the Jewish community and around the world, and Jewish citizens in Israel, the United States, and Europe tend to be supportive of a robust welfare state.

Judaism and divorce

- Although divorce is common in today's social landscape, prevailing wisdom says that up to half of all marriages will end in divorce, it is still a heartbreaking way to end a marriage.
- Unlike some religions, however, which do not permit divorce, Judaism recognizes the necessity under certain circumstances.
- Just as marriage is a metaphysical reality, two souls fusing together to create one complete soul, so too divorce is a metaphysical reality.

-For a Jewish couple to become divorced, the man must give the woman a document called a "Get," as prescribed in the Torah (Deut. 24:1-4).

-A Get terminates the Jewish marriage and certifies that the couple is now free to remarry according to Jewish law.

Jewish marriage

-Jewish marriage is not merely a secular legal partnership, but a union sanctified by God.

-Marital obligations, therefore, are not merely personal, but have implications for universal harmony.

- The existence of God as a “silent partner” in Jewish marriage endows a relationship with sanctity and solemn commitment.

-Judaism views marriage as the basis of human companionship and the cornerstone of Jewish community.

- As the venue for fulfillment of the biblical commandment, “be fruitful and multiply”, Jewish marriage is also the basis of Jewish survival.

-Desirable times for a Jewish wedding have been set by both custom and law, but Jewish weddings traditionally are not held on the Sabbath; on the holidays of Rosh Hashanah, Yom Kippur, Passover, Shavuot, and the first and last days of Sukkot; and around certain fast days.

-The importance of marriage in Jewish tradition is grounded in the Bible, with God declaring before he creates Eve to be Adam's helpmeet that It is not good that the man should be alone (Genesis 2:18).

- Marriage is vitally important in Judaism.

-Refraining from marriage is not considered holy, as it is in some other religions. On the contrary, it is considered unnatural.

-The Talmud says that an unmarried man is constantly thinking of sin.

-The Talmud tells of a rabbi who was introduced to a young unmarried rabbi. The older rabbi told the younger one not to come into his presence again until he was married.

-Marriage is not solely, or even primarily, for the purpose of procreation.

-Traditional sources recognize that companionship, love and intimacy are the primary purposes of marriage, noting that woman was created in Gen. 2:18 because "it is not good for man to be alone," rather than because she was necessary for procreation.

ISLAM

AUTHORITY OF THE QURAN (KORAN)

The quran has supreme authority for the Muslims because:

- They believe it contains the exact words of Allah.
- It was brought to people through the final prophet Muhammad (s.a.w) as a message to all of mankind.
- It was recited exactly by the prophet & recorded immediately & accurately by his companions.
- It has never been changed, so they are sure their knowledge is correct.
- It's a miracle from Allah because Prophet Muhammad (s.a.w) didn't know how to read & write.
- It shows them how to follow the straight path.
- It inspires them to struggle in the cause of Allah.
- It makes clear to them their obligations & duties towards Allah.

- It enables them to practice their religion properly & to be guided.
- It encourages them through the examples of faithful believers.
- It develops love for Allah.

Respect for the quran.

- Muslims show respect for the quran by performing **wudhu** before touching it.
 - Keeping it on a high place.
 - Trying to follow & practice upon what it says.
 - Reading it every day.
 - Avoid eating & drinking whilst reading.
 - Handle it with respect.
-
- Importance of revelation of holy quran to Prophet Muhammad
 - Revealed on the **night of power** in the cave of ***hira*** on the mountain of light ***jabal an-nur***.
 - It was the time when the first words of the quran were revealed.
 - He became the final chosen messenger because he received this message from Allah.
 - It proves that the quran is the word of Allah.
 - It was the beginning of many such revelations which continued for a period of 23 years.

- Quran is regarded as a great miracle.
- It restored the original message sent to previous prophets & clarified the errors of previous nations.
- Every sound structure must have a solid foundation in order to remain strong. Islam's foundation is the five pillars it was built upon, forming the basis of Islamic teaching as taught by Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him), wherein he said:

PILLARS OF ISLAM

- Islam is built upon five pillars:
- The Declaration of Faith (Shahadah);
 2. Establishing regular prayers (Salah);
 3. Paying Charity (Zakah);
 4. Fasting the (lunar) month of Ramadan (Sawm);
 5. Pilgrimage (Hajj)
- These five pillars are a cornerstone of a Muslim's life.

Declaration of Faith – SHAHADAH

- The declaration of faith is bearing witness (testifying) that there is no deity worthy of worship but Allah (God), and that Muhammad (peace be upon him) is His Servant and Messenger. It must be based on a sincere and firm belief in the heart, as well as being uttered verbally.
- The first part of the declaration implies that:
- No person, object or being has the right to be worshipped except Allah alone. The Arabic name "Allah" refers to the One True God of all mankind and everything that exists.
- Allah alone is the Creator and Sustainer of all that exists, and He has power over all things.
- Allah alone has perfect attributes and is free from all deficiencies.

- Allah has no partner, equal, father, mother or son.
- The second part of the declaration is that Muhammad (peace be upon him) is Allah's Servant and final Messenger. He is the final Prophet in a long chain of Prophets sent to call the people to the obedience and worship of Allah alone. Some of these Prophets include Adam, Noah, Abraham, Ishmael, Isaac, Jacob, Joseph, Moses, David, Solomon and Jesus (peace be upon them all).
- The Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him) was sent with the Qur'an (the final revelation), in order to teach the people Allah's message, and serve as an example for all to follow.
- Some benefits of the Declaration of Faith:
- Complete surrender to the will of Allah and becoming His true servant and subject.
- Produces a high degree of self-respect and confidence, while also remaining humble and modest.
- Produces strong determination, patience and perseverance, making a person brave and courageous, as well as dutiful and upright.
- Makes a person obey and observe Allah's commands.

The Prayer – SALAH

- "Indeed, I am Allah! There is none worthy of worship but I, so worship Me and offer the prayer for My remembrance." Qur'an 20:14
- The five daily prayers form the most important ritual of worship in a Muslim's life; one each at dawn, noon, mid-afternoon, sunset and nightfall. Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him) said: **"Prayer is a pillar of the religion (Islam). Whoever establishes it, establishes religion; and whoever destroys it (e.g. neglects it), destroys religion."**
- Prayer establishes a personal and spiritual connection between the Muslim and his Creator, based on faith, love, hope and reverence. When prayer is performed correctly with complete concentration, humility and sincerity, it will have an enduring effect on the person, filling his heart with contentment, peace and

closeness with Allah.

- Prayer is the centre of a Muslim's life and the best way to achieve submission to Allah. It can be offered almost anywhere clean: such as in fields, offices, factories or universities; and takes only a few minutes to perform. It consists of recitation from the Holy Qur'an, supplicating to and praising Allah, with various body postures such as standing, bowing, prostrating and sitting. Through prayer, the Muslim remembers the greatness of his Creator and supplicates to Him for his needs and wishes.
- Repeatedly humbling oneself before Allah prevents a person from falling into sin, and is a type of purification for one's soul, as mentioned in the Qur'an: **"Verily, the prayer prevents one from the shameful and evil deeds."** Qur'an 29:45. Prayer is also an opportunity for repentance and seeking forgiveness from Allah.
- The Messenger of Allah (peace be upon him) asked his companions, **"If one of you had a river by his door in which he bathed five times a day, would any filth remain on him?"** They replied, **"No."** Then the Prophet added **"Likewise, Allah wipes away sins with the five daily prayers."**

The Prescribed Charity – ZAKAH

- "Those who establish the prayer (salah) and give the charity (zakah) ...these are the ones who will prosper."Qur'an 31:4-5
- All things belong to Allah, including wealth, which is considered as a trust. The prescribed charity (zakah) is an obligation on every Muslim who meets certain criteria (e.g. attained maturity, is sane, has wealth above a certain threshold). A small portion of wealth (includes 2.5% monetary and may include other assets) which must be paid annually to those who are eligible, as prescribed in the Qur'an (e.g. the poor and needy).
- The Prophet (peace be on him) said:**"Allah has made zakah obligatory simply to purify your remaining wealth."**
- The meaning of the word "zakah", is both 'purification' and 'growth'. This is similar to the pruning of plants, whereby regularly trimming provides balance

and encourages growth. By fulfilling this obligation, Muslims purify their remaining wealth, as well as ensure both financial and spiritual growth.

- Some benefits of zakah:
- Purifies one from selfishness, arrogance and a greedy heart.
- Trains one to be sympathetic and compassionate towards the poor and needy.
- Reminds one of the blessings from Allah and encourages one to be grateful.
- Bridges the gap between different socio-economic classes and groups, and is a form of social security.
- Reduces poverty and ensures equality by making it obligatory upon the rich to share some of their wealth with the less fortunate “..so that this (wealth) may not circulate solely among the rich from among you.” Qur’an 59:7
- A person may also give as much as they please as additional voluntary charity.

Fasting – SAWM

- “Fasting is prescribed for you as it was prescribed for those before you, that you may attain piety.” Qur’an 2:183
- As with any act of worship, fasting requires obedience and submission to Allah’s commands through the highest degree of commitment and sincerity. Every year during the month of Ramadan (the 9th month of the lunar calendar), Muslims fast from dawn until sunset, abstaining from three key human needs – food, drink and sexual relations. One should also abstain from all sinful actions.
- Fasting during Ramadan is obligatory on every physically and mentally capable adult Muslim. Children, the sick, the mentally unfit, the elderly, menstruating women, and travellers are exempt.
- Some benefits of fasting:
- Promotes spiritual self-purification and growth.
- Scientifically proven health benefits.
- Sympathy for those less fortunate, prompting more charity.

- A means of learning self-restraint and patience.
- Purifies the soul and helps it acquire the habit of obeying Allah by restraining desires, and promotes steadfastness.
- Creates an increased feeling of unity and collective identity amongst those fasting.
- Creates an increased awareness about the state of affairs across the globe and the hardships endured.
- Forgiveness of sins. The Prophet (peace be upon him) said, “He who fasts Ramadan, with faith and hoping for reward (from Allah), then his past sins are forgiven.”

Pilgrimage – HAJJ

- “And Hajj (pilgrimage to Makkah) to the House (Ka’bah) is a duty that mankind owes to Allah, for those who can afford the expenses (for one’s transportation, provision and residence).” Qur’an 3:97
- Pilgrimage to the Holy city of Makkah (in Saudi Arabia) and other sacred sites must be performed at least once in a person’s life, if they are physically and financially capable.
- Performing the pilgrimage is a temporary suspension of all worldly activities, and is a time for one to reflect, worship, seek the forgiveness of Allah and attain His closeness.
- The Pilgrimage is an annual event in the 12th month of the lunar calendar (Dhul-Hijjah in Arabic), which unifies people of every colour, race, status and age, as they join in worship of the One True God. All pilgrims wear simple and similar clothing, which strips away distinctions of class and culture, so that all stand equal before Allah.
- Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him) said, **“Whoever performs Hajj and does not utter obscenities or commit sin, will come back just like the day when his mother bore him (i.e. pure of sins).”**
- Hajj involves following in the footsteps of Prophet Abraham, as taught to us by

Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon them). This great act of worship consists of many components including sacrificing an animal, supplicating, visiting and praying at various sites, circling the Ka'bah, walking between two mountains, as well as many other rituals, all of which are performed over a period of 6 continuous days.

- Such an experience is life-altering and humbles a person, making them more patient and thankful to Allah. Brotherhood is increased, as is the sense that all Muslims, regardless of their differences, are one nation.

Conclusion

- The five pillars of Islam have been prescribed by Allah, and a Muslim is required to believe and act according to them. They are practical as well as easy, and the blessings and wisdom behind them are manifold. When put into perspective, they contribute to the well being of both the individual and the society, enhancing the character and manners of the individual, and making both society and individuals accountable and closer to Allah.
- These noble pillars of Islam are purely for the benefit of His creation, as Allah (Glory be to Him!) is free of all needs. These five pillars provide the solid structure and 'training programme' for the betterment and success of all humanity.

THE SHARIA LAW

- Monotheism, belief in one God, is the most important and foundational concept in Islam.
- -Muslims believe in one God who created the universe and has power over everything within it.
- -He is unique and exalted above everything He creates, and His greatness cannot be compared to His creation.

- -Furthermore, He is the only one deserving of any worship and the ultimate purpose of all creation is to submit to Him.
- -The Islamic understanding of God is distinct from all other religions and beliefs in various respects since it is based on a pure and clear understanding of monotheism.
- -This essentially captures the concept of God in Islam, which will be further elaborated in this pamphlet.
- Muslims often refer to God as *Allah*.
- This is a universal name for God and does not refer to an exclusively 'Islamic' God.
- Interestingly, this name is related to the Aramaic and Hebrew names for God, *Allaha* and *Elohim*.
- -Therefore, *Allah* is simply the Arabic name for God which affirms that He is One singular God with no partners or equals.
- The name *Allah* cannot be pluralized or limited to a specific gender, which establishes that God is One and that He is unique from everything He creates.
- Muslims continue to use this original Arabic name for God (*Allah*) since it perfectly expresses His unique qualities.
- God is the Creator and the Sustainer of the universe who created everything for a reason. Muslims believe that He created humankind with a simple purpose – to worship Him.
- He sent messengers to guide people in fulfilling this purpose. Some of these messengers include Adam, Noah, Abraham, Moses, Jesus, and Muhammad, peace be upon all of them.
- They all taught a consistent message about God by affirming His greatness as the Creator and guiding people to worship Him alone.

- This basic concept has always resonated with people's natural understanding of God.
- When the final prophet, Muhammad, peace be upon him (pbuh), was asked about God, the answer came directly from God in the holy book of Muslims, the Quran (also spelled 'Koran'): *"Say, He is God the One, God the eternal. He begot no one nor was He begotten. No one is comparable to Him."* [112:1-4]
- This is a clear statement by God describing Himself to humanity without any room for confusion.
- God is One and is exalted above everything He creates and He is capable over all things.
- Sharia law is the law of Islam.
- The Sharia (also spelled *Shari'a* or *Shariah*) law is cast from Muhammad's words, called "*hadith*," his actions, called "*sunna*h," and the Quran, which he dictated.
- Sharia law itself cannot be altered, but the interpretation of Sharia law, called "*fiqh*," by muftis (Islamic jurists) is given some latitude.
- As a legal system, Sharia law is exceptionally broad. While other legal codes regulate public behavior, Sharia law regulates public behavior, private behavior, and even private beliefs.
- Compared to other legal codes, Sharia law also prioritizes punishment over rehabilitation, and the penalties under Sharia law favor corporal and capital punishments over incarceration.
- Of all legal systems in the world today, Sharia law is deemed the most intrusive and restrictive, especially against women (see below), and is making inroads into Western democracies.

According to Sharia law (see links for details):

- Theft is punishable by amputation of the hands (**Quran 5:38** - includes graphic image).
 - Criticizing or denying any part of the **Quran** is punishable by death.
 - Criticizing **Muhammad** or denying that he is a prophet is punishable by death.
 - Criticizing or denying Allah is punishable by death .
 - A Muslim who becomes a non-Muslim is punishable by death.
 - A non-Muslim who leads a Muslim away from Islam is punishable by death.
 - A non-Muslim man who marries a Muslim woman is punishable by death.
 - A woman or girl who has been raped cannot testify in court against her rapist(s).
 - Testimonies of 4 male witnesses are required to prove rape of a female (**Quran 24:13**).
 - A woman or girl who alleges rape without producing 4 male witnesses is guilty of adultery.
 - A woman or girl found guilty of adultery is punishable by death.
 - A male convicted of rape can have his conviction dismissed by marrying his victim.
 - Muslim men have sexual rights to any woman/ girl not wearing the **Hijab**.
 - A woman can have 1 husband, who can have up to 4 wives; **Muhammad** can have more.
 - A man can marry an infant girl and consummate the marriage when she is **9 years old**.
 - Girls' clitoris should be cut (**Muhammad**'s words, *Book 41, Kitab Al-Adab, Hadith 5251*).
 - A man can beat his wife for insubordination (see **Quran 4:34** and **Religion of Peace**).
 - A man can unilaterally divorce his wife; a wife needs her husband's consent to divorce.

- A divorced wife loses custody of all children over 6 years of age or when they exceed it.
- A woman's testimony in court, allowed in property cases, carries ½ the weight of a man's.
- A female heir inherits half of what a male heir inherits .
- A woman cannot drive a car, as it leads to *fitnah* (upheaval).
- A woman cannot speak alone to a man who is not her husband or relative.
- Meat to eat must come from animals that have been sacrificed to Allah - i.e., be "**Halal**."
- Muslims are to subjugate the world under Islam.
- Muslims should engage in **Taqiyya** and lie to non-Muslims to advance Islam.

Who Is the Prophet Muhammad ?

- Muhammad was born in Makkah in the year 570. Since his father died before his birth and his mother died shortly thereafter, he was raised by his uncle who was from the respected tribe of Quraysh.

1. He was the final Messenger sent by God to the entirety of humanity.

- Allah states in the Quran:

“Muhammad is not the father of any of your men, but (he is) the Apostle of God, and the Seal of the Prophets: and God has full knowledge of all things. Quran 33:40

- Thawban also narrated that the Messenger of Allah said:

“..And I am the last of the Prophets, there is no Prophet after me.”

2. He was given the Quran, the final revelation of God.

- Allah states in the Quran:

He has sent down upon you, [O Muhammad], the Book in truth, confirming what was before it. And He revealed the Torah and the Gospel. Quran 3:3

3. He was granted the largest following.

- The Messenger of Allah said:
“Amongst the apostles I would have the largest following on the Day of Resurrection, and I would be the first to knock at the door of Paradise.”

4. He is the leader of the children of Adam.

5. He will be the first to be resurrected.

6. He will be the first to intercede on the Day of Judgement.

- Abu Hurayrah, narrated that the Messenger of Allah said:

“I will be the leader of the sons of Adam on the Day of Resurrection, and the first one for whom the grave will be opened, and the first to intercede, and the first whose intercession will be accepted.”

7. He will be the first to cross the Siraat bridge over Hell Fire.

“I was sitting with Abu Hurairah and Abu Sa’eed. One of them narrated the hadith about intercession and the other was listening. He said: ‘Then the angels will come and intercede, and the messengers will intercede.

‘The Messenger of Allah said: I will be the first one to cross it...’

8. He will be the first to enter Paradise.

- Anas bin Malik narrated that the Prophet said:

“I will come to the gate of Paradise on the Day of Resurrection and will ask for it to be opened. The keeper will say: ‘Who are you?’ I will say, ‘Muhammad.’ He will say: ‘I was commanded not to open it for anyone before you.’

9. He was granted the Maqaam Al-Mahmoud (The Praised Station).

- Allah states in the Quran:
- *“It may be that your Lord will raise you to Maqaam Al-Mahmoud (a station of praise and glory).” Quran 17:79*

10. He led all the Prophets in Prayer during the Night Journey.

- This proves that our Prophet Muhammad is the greatest leader, and as it was stated by Ibn Katheer at the beginning of his commentary on Surah Al-Isra': "Then his honourable status and superiority to them was manifested when he was made to go forward to lead them in prayer, when Jibreel (peace be upon him) indicated to him that he should do so."
- These are just a selection of the proofs that indicate that the Prophet Muhammad was the greatest of all Prophets to have walked this Earth. May the peace and blessings of Allah, God Almighty, be upon him, his family and his companions.

THE STATUS OF WOMEN IN ISLAM

Introduction

- The status of women in Islam is one of the crucial topics and dominant themes in the modern era, which theologians have been studying. Islam regards men and women as being of the same essence created from a single soul. A woman has a completely independent personality in Islam. In this paper, I will provide an overview of the status of women in Islam in general and then I will focus on the issue of equality.
- One important part of the discussion will be devoted to clarify the conceptual context and the relevant terminology of the subject of inheritance and to explain certain rulings of inheritance in Islamic law that may seem at first glance to be in conflict with the idea of equality.
- In the Islamic perspective, a woman has an honoured position. She has special respect, love, affection and gentle feeling along with her legal and civil rights.
- Actually Islam expresses the best explanation for a woman's true image in the following verses from the Qur'an:
- We have enjoined man to be kind to his parents.

- His mother has carried him in travail, and bore him in travail, and his gestation and weaning take thirty months.
- When he comes of age and reaches forty years, he says, *‘My Lord! Inspire me to give thanks for Your blessing with which You have blessed me and my parents, and that I may do righteous deeds which may please You, and invest my descendants with righteousness. Indeed I have turned to you in penitence, and I am one of the muslims.’* (46:15)
- Your Lord has decreed that you shall not worship anyone except Him, and [He has enjoined] kindness to parents.
- Should they reach old age at your side – one of them or both- do not say to them, ‘Fie!’ And do not chide them, but speak to them noble words. Lower the wing of humility to them, out of mercy, and say, *‘My Lord! Have mercy on them, just as they reared me when I was [a] small [child].’* (17:23 & 24)
- *‘Do not covet the advantage which God has given some of you over others. To men belongs a share of what they have earned, and to women a share of what they have earned. And ask God for His grace’.* (4:32)
- Similar to the Qur’an, the Prophetic hadiths also emphasize the honour and respect of women within such a frame of love, endearment and affection.
- This is especially true when the hadiths teach about the mother, the wife and the daughter. For example, the Prophet said:
‘Observe your duty to God in respect to the women, and recommend them to be well treated’.
- He also said:
‘I do not think that a man gets better in faith without loving women better’.
- The Prophet had a daughter whom he loved very deeply and tenderly. He used to say: *‘Fatimah is a part of me; whoever wrongs her wrongs me and who pleases her pleases me.’*

- He visited her frequently; and on his return from any journey he called on her first before going to his own home. Whenever she approached, his eyes glowed with joy. He would take her in his arm, kiss her warmly and offer her his own seat. Indeed this kind, tender pattern is an ideal model for mankind.
- A man came to the Prophet and asked him, “*O messenger of God! Whom should I be more dutiful to?*” The Prophet replied: “*To your mother.*” He asked, then to whom. Then he replied: “*To your mother.*” The man again asked, then to whom. Then the Prophet replied: “*To your father.*”

Equality

- Islam considers both men and women equally human and grants them equal human rights.
- Though their tasks and functions may sometimes differ, they both have opportunities for achieving perfection and closeness to God. T
- the following verses from the Qur’an and sayings of the Prophet support this argument. For example, God says:

‘mankind! Indeed We created you from a male and a female, and made you nations and tribes that you may identify with one another. Indeed the noblest of you in the sight of God is the most Godwary among you. Indeed God is All-knowing, All-aware. (49:13)

‘mankind! Be wary of your Lord who created you from a single soul, and created its mate from it, and, from the two of them, scattered numerous men and women’. (4:1)

- Also Prophet Muhammad (S) said:

“*All people are equal, as the teeth of a comb*”. There is no claim of merit of an Arab and non-Arab, or a white over a black person, or a male over a female.
- Only Allah-fearing people merit a preference with God.

- The most important sources in Islamic thought i.e. the Qur'an and Sunnah both confer the great message of universal equality among all mankind. The above texts are just a few examples and there are many more available.
- Apart from this, there are hundreds of verses which take the form of address: "O mankind, or "O believer" which refer to both men and women. Both have similar duties to perform; for instance prayer, rituals, fasting, to command to good and to prohibit from evil. Moral virtues such as tolerance, truthfulness, honesty are required from both.
- According to Islam, personal superiority is only based on piety.
- Islam's regard for women is not simply giving her a chance to survive.
- Muslims, men and women, are told to seek knowledge and education wherever they find it and to use this knowledge to help fellow human beings.
- This is a duty about which they will be questioned on Judgment Day.
- History tells us about the immense contribution of Muslim women to the community. One lady i.e. the Lady Khadijah, daughter of Khuwaylid, and one young boy were the first to believe in Islam. Lady Khadijah was a great supporter of Islam and the Prophet.

Ethics :- Meaning and Definition?

Literal Meaning :- In literal sense the word " Ethics" means character, nature and disposition.

Technical Meaning :- Ethics is the area of study concerned with what is morally good and what is morally bad.

Ethical Teachings in the Qur'an :-

The Ethical Teachings in the Qur'an are :-

1. **Worship only Allah :-** And your Lord has decreed that you worship none but Him (17:23)
2. **Be Kind, humble and honorable to one's parents:-** And that you be kind (Dutiful) to one's parents if one of or both of them attain old age in your life, say not to them a word of disrespect, nor shout at them but address them in terms of honor(17:23/4:36).
3. **Be Neither miserly nor wasteful in one's expenditure: -** And spend not wastefully (your wealth) in the manner of a spendthrift. Verily, spendthrift are brothers of the devils (Shyatin) (17:26-27).
4. **Do not engage in mercy killings for fear of starvation: -** And kill not your children for fear of poverty (starvation). We shall provide for them as well as for you. Surely, the killing of them is a grave sin (17:31).
5. **Do not commit adultery:-** And come not near to the unlawful sex. Verily, it is a Fahishah (grave sin) and an evil way (17:32).
6. **Do not kill unjustly:-** And don't kill anyone whose killing Allah has forbidden, expect for just cause (17:33).
7. **Care for orphaned children:-** And come not near to the orphan's property expect to improve it, until he attains the age of strength (17:34).
8. **Fulfill promises:-** And fulfill (every) covenant. Verily! The covenant will be questioned about (17:34).

- 9. Be honest and fair in one's interactions:-** And give full measure when you measure and weigh with a balance that is straight. That is good (advantageous) and better in the end (17:35).
- 10. Do not walk on earth arrogantly:-** And walk not on earth with conceit and arrogance. Verily! You can neither rend nor penetrate the earth, nor can you attain a stature like the mountains in height (17:37/31:18).
- 11. Fear Allah and speak truth:-** O you who believe! Keep your duty to Allah and fear him, and speak (always) the truth (33:70).
- 12. Remain away from intoxicants and gambling:-** O you who believe! Intoxicants (all kind of alcoholic drinks), gambling, Al-Ansab and Al-Azlam (arrows for seeking luck or decision) are an abomination of Satan's handiwork. So, avoid (strictly all) that (abomination) in order that you may be successful (5:90).
- 13. Be good and kind towards relatives and neighbours:-** And do good to kinsfolk (relatives), orphans, the poor, the neighbor who is near of kin, the neighbor who is a stranger, the company by your side, the wayfarer (you meet) (4:36)

Significance of Ethics:

The significance of ethics can be explained and understood by the following points:-

- 1. Realization of creator and creation:-** Ethics helps in realization of our creator, Allah. It is because of ethics a man gets acquainted with the purpose of creation also.
- 2. Elevation and Purification of Souls:-** Man's soul gets elevated by the ethics. It also gets Med and begins to realize the purpose of life on earth.

3. **Abolishment of discrimination:-** Ethics plays a pivotal role in promoting equality and abolishes discrimination on various grounds such as class, creed, caste, color, sex, language, nationality, religion etc.
4. **Civilization of human beings:-** Ethics frees human beings from beastly instincts and civilizes them.
5. **Man gets pleasure, goodwill and nearness of God:-** It is the quality of ethics by which man gets pleasure, goodwill and nearness to his creator.
6. **Executer of good morals and Abstainer of bad morals:-** Ethics helps a man in the execution of good morals and at the same time he himself abstains from bad morals.
7. **Selfishness ends:-** A selfless behavior and attitude develops in people because of ethics. Simplicity, honesty, love, sympathy, piety, justice, truthfulness and modesty become the virtues of people.

Concept of J iihad

Meaning of J iihad

-J iihad is an Arabic term, and its plain connotation is “to strive or work hard for something”. So, it does not mean “the Holy War” against non- Muslims, which the West has associated with it.

-The absolute analysis of this religious action is divided in to two sections, Major and Minor J iihad.

-The former is a spiritual effort which binds a Muslim to fight its inner self against the satanic desires. It is an ongoing process throughout one`s life till death.

-The latter form is the physical struggle against the enemies of Islam. But it is greatly

mistaken as a means of violence, although in Islam, there is no room for killing of blameless, but should only be used for defending oneself against the enemies.

- For further elaborating the delicacy of this matter, let us discuss it in the light of the Holy Quran and the Sunnah of the Holy Prophet (PBUH).

Islam and Environment.

-Environment protection is an important aspect of Islam. Being stewards of the Earth, it is the responsibility of Muslims to care for the environment in a proactive manner.

-There is a definite purpose behind the creation of different species, be it plants or animals.

- Muslims are encouraged to reflect on the relationship between living organisms and their environment and to maintain the ecological balance created by Allah.

- Protection of the environment is essential to Islamic beliefs and mankind has the responsibility to ensure safe custody of the environment.

PRINCIPLES OF GOOD GOVERNANCE IN ISLAM

-Islamic view of good governance is qualitative and not mechanical. Major features of good governance can be précised under seven fundamentals

1. Rules of Law (As-Shura)
2. Khilafah
3. Accountability
4. Transparency
5. Justice

6. Equity

7. Al-amr bil maruf wa nahi an al-munkar

1. Rules of Law (As-Shura)

-As-shura is one of the most important constitutional principles in the Islamic Law. As it's very important that's why it's been mentioned in Quran Moreover, a sura (chapter) in the holy Qur'an was named after that principle. It is called "Shura". This shows the importance of this principle in all the affairs of Muslims.

-The whole system of the Islamic state from its beginning to the selection of the Khalifa of the state and all those in key positions as well as its communications must be led by Shura, so it should be carried out directly or indirectly over selected or nominated councils

-There is mention in Quran: O you, who believe, be custodians of justice (and) witness for Allah, even though against yourselves or your parents or your relatives. Whether a man is rich or poor, Allah is the greatest well-wisher than you. So follow not the behests of lust, lest you swerve from justice (Quran, An-Nisa, 4:135)

-Even the Prophet, although he was the receiver of direct guidance from the Almighty Allah, was commanded. Allah says:

-Consult them in affairs (of moment). Then, when you have to take a decision put the trust in Allah. For Allah loves those who put their trust (in Him). (Quran, Al-Imran, 3:159)

-Following this advice and lead, Khalifa Umar admonished that:

-There is no khilafah without consultation.

-Thus, The same mechanism was followed by the follower of Muhammad SWT for the selection of Khalifa and It was the first Muslim elected four khulafah guidance, although the selection and approval process varies. The important principle is the truth and accountability and public confidence in those elected by the community.

The importance of Shura

-The basic fundamentals of Islamic political system is called Shura.its is responsible for all the affairs of Muslims .Thus, the Islamic state might have preceded the modern democratic systems with regard to the necessity of agreement over choosing the one who runs its affairs and cares for its interests, something which stresses the value and effectiveness of unanimity among Muslims (Al-Nuzum, p24, 25) .

2. Khilafah

-Khalifa is an Arabic word means successor. The word caliph is simply an Anglicized version of khalifa. The terms khilafat and caliphate, though derived from khalifa and caliph individually, have different meanings.

-Khilafat refers to the Islamic institution of spiritual successor ship, whereas caliphate indicates a politico-religious Muslim state governed by a caliph

-When the Prophet Muhammed SAW past a way in (632 C.E.), Hazrat Abu Bakr succeeded to his spiritual, administrative purposes as successor of the messenger of God (khalifa rasul Allah). Bernard Lewis, the preeminent historian of Islam, observes:

“Abu Bakr was given the title of Khalifa or ‘Deputy’ (of the prophet) ...and his election marks the appointment of the great historic institution of the Caliphate.

-His voters can have no idea of later purposes and growth of the office. At the time, they made no effort to define his duties or powers.

-The only state of his selection was the maintenance of the inheritance of the Prophet.” (Lewis, 1993)

-Allah has promised to those among you who believe and act rightly, that He will surely make them Successors (khalifas) in the earth, as He made Successors from among those who were before them; and that He will surely establish for them their religion, which He has chosen for them; and that He will surely grant them security and peace in place of their fear (Quran, Alnoor, 24:54)

-In this verse, the Holy Quran presents the institution of khilafat as a reward for collective virtue. It is often understood to provide a basis for an Islamic organization

founded upon the democratic lines headed by a khalifa whose office is, in principle, elective and bound by the Quran and the sunnah.

-In a well-known hadith, the Prophet Muhammad SWT is reported to have observed:

-Prophet Hood shall remain among you as long as God wills.

-Then khilafat on the pattern of prophet hood will commence and remain as long as He wills. A corrupt monarchy shall then follow and it shall remain as long as God wills.

-There shall then be a oppressive despotism which shall remain as long as God wills. Then once again khilafat will arise on the principle of prophet hood (Masnad-Ahmad)

-This hadith not only reassures us about the repetition of well guided khilafat but it also permits a historical judgment on what was to follow the early Khilafat.

-The famous historian of Islam, Muhammad SWT ibn Jarir Al Tabari, narrates the following incident

-Umar said to Salman: 'Am I a king or a khalifa?' and Salman answered: 'If you have levied from the lands of the Muslims one dirham, or more, or less, and applied it unlawfully, you are a king not a khalifa'. And Umar wept

-Here Hazrat Umar, the second Khalifa, whose goodness, sense of justice, and puritanical strictness were well-known, came to tears by the mere mention of the possibility of misusing a single coin from the public exchequer.

-This incidence underscores the characteristic of the rightly-guided khilafat. (Al Tabari, Tarikh al-Rusul Wal Muluk)

-As God's sovereignty extends over the universe, the final ideal of a public in Islam is a universal federation or association of independent states, related together for maintenance freedom of integrity, for the maintenance of peace, and for cooperation in promoting human welfare throughout the world (Khan, Feb 1993)

-A khalifa has the promise of divine support so long as it remains firmly based on the precept of prophet hood – that is, the principles and prototypes demonstrated by prophets.

-He is bound by the rules of great law. He decides questions of rule after discussion with the chosen representatives of the people.

-In governing the corporation, man is seen as the essential element for the system to be effectively working in the right way. As man is the shareholder, creditor, examiner, regulator, manager as well as the director thus, it is manifest that man plays the principal roles in managing and led to the accomplishment of company's vision and mission.

-The issues of man in term of values, ethics and moral conduct therefore need to be well detained in the first place to ensure the concern of the society could be taken care.

-The concern among other things are maintenance trust, maintaining honesty, exercising transparency and accountability, traditional in managing resources, caring and concern of the environment.

-The failure to impress these values may pose serious problem to the public at large.

3. Accountability

-In the Holy Qur'an, the word hesab is repeated more than eight times in different verses (F, 1997) Hesab or 'account' is the root of accounting, and the references in the Holy Qur'an are to 'account' in its generic sense, relating to one's responsibility to 'account' to God on all matters relating to human effort for which every Muslim is 'accountable'.

-The Muslims believe in the terms of accountability that they will be judged for whatever they do in this world in the hereafter (life after death).

- In Islam, It's the duty of each Muslim to fulfill the wills of Allah in order to seek his pleasure and the promised prizes in the life after death.

-Thus, it requires every action and word in this world must be in line with the Islamic teachings. It does not matter what action the Muslims do either ibadah (solah) or purchasing shares in the stock market, eating , sleeping like daily jobs they must follow the Islamic teaching framework carefully.

- The importance of accountability to the man's life also has been mentioned by Holy Quran: *"..Lo the hearing and the sight and the heart – of each of these will be asked"* (Quran, Bani Israill, 17:36)

-Abdullah reported that Allah's Messenger Muhammad SWT said: Every one of you is a guardian and accountable (mas'ul) for his charge.

-Thus the Khalifa is a custodian of the people and He is responsible for them.

- And a man is a guardian of his household and he is accountable for them; and a woman is in charge of the household and her children and she is accountable for them; and a servant is guardian of his master's property, every one of you is accountable for his subjects (Bukhari)

-In the view of corporate governance practices, as far as Islam is concerned, the country directors, management as well as the auditor should perform their professional duties with the objective of satisfying the needs of the Public and to Allah as well.

- Supposing, there should be no such disease (i.e. fraud; material misstatement) exist in the country if this concept could be affected and could be reflected in their conducts. Unfortunately, most of them have been followed by the physical experienced life which has led to the bad behaviors that cause the owners (community) of the country suffer the penalties.

4. Transparency

-The concept of transparency has been divulged by Allah in the following Ayat: *"O you who believe! When you deal with each other, in transactions involving future obligations in a fixed period of time, reduce them to writing. Let a scribe write-down faithfully as between the parties..."* (Quran, Al-Baqarah, Beginning of the Ayat, 2:282). This verse states that every transaction must be written to avoid justice.

-Applying the concept of transparency, corporation should also disclose information regarding its strategy, actions, contribution to the community and the use of resources and protection of environment (Haniffa, 2002)

- Transparency is the necessity for openness in all public affairs.
- Transparency allows Committee to gather information that may be unsafe to exposure misuses and defending their benefits.
- According to Ayee transparency entails that: citizens have a right to available information pertaining to, for example, award of contracts, privatization of state enterprises, rules against corruption or the funding of political parties (Ayee, 2000).
- A transparent government is that which offers chance to citizens to find out the true proofs at first hand, without the material being changed or presented through a misrepresenting mirror.
- In core, transparency is basically concerned with open and established system of government, the extermination of corruption and the institutionalization of a system that is fair, just and based on the rule of law.
- Transparency or openness in governance is important in the process of growth.
- It is serious in the elimination of corruption and the promotion of responsibility in the conduct of government business.
- Today, the quest for transparent performance has become a world-wide phenomenon with the Transparency International.

5. Justice

- In the Islamic worldview, justice means placing things in their rightful place. It also means giving others equal treatment.
- In Islam, justice is also an honest quality and a feature of human personality, as it is in the Western tradition. Justice is close to equality in the wisdom that it creates a state of equilibrium in the distribution of rights and duties, but they are not equal.
- Sometimes, justice is accomplished through inequality, like in unequal distribution of wealth. (Muslims)
- Justice in the Islamic governmental system, including social justice, which means

that the government should arrange to meet and please the needs and needs of all the people as they have a valid part of the country and citizens of the country.

- This contains the facility of job, means of existence and financial justice.

- This in turn suggests that it is the duty of the government to provide food, housing and clothing for all the people in the country.

- Economic justice aimed at equitable supply of lifestyle and checks the awareness of wealth in a few hands.

The Importance of Justice

- The Quran, the holy scripture of Islam, considers justice to be a highest virtue. It is a basic objective of Islam to the degree that it stands next in order of importance to belief in God's exclusive right to worship (Tawheed) and the truth of Muhammad SWT prophet hood. God declares in the Quran: God commands justice and fair dealing... (Quran, Al-Nahal, 16:90).

And in another passage:

"you who believe, be upright for God, and (be) bearers of witness with justice!.. (Quran, Al-Mayeeda, 5:8).

- Therefore, one may achieve that justice is an responsibility of Islam and unfairness is forbidden. The importance of justice to the Quranic value system is showed by the following verse:

- We sent Our Messengers with clear signs and sent down with them the Book and the Measure in order to establish justice among the people...(Quran, Al-Hadeed, 57:25).

- The phrase 'Our Messengers' shows that justice has been the goal of all admission and scriptures sent to humanity.

- The verse also shows that justice must be measured and applied by the values and rules set by admission. Islam's approach to justice is complete and complete.

- Any path that leads to justice is believed to be in accord with Islamic Law.

-God has required justice and, although He has not prescribed a definite path, has provided general rules, on how to achieve it.

-He has neither given a fixed means by which it can be found, nor has He stated unacceptable any specific means or methods that can lead to justice.

-Therefore, all means, processes, and methods that enable, improve, and advance the cause of justice, and do not interrupt the Islamic Law are valid (Qarzawi)

6. Equity

-The principle of equality is one of the most important constitutional principles upon which the contemporary system rests.

-This means that the principle of equality contained in the individual communities are equal in rights, responsibilities and public duties that will be enjoyed by all without discrimination of race, origin, language or belief.

-The principle of equality has been initiated by the Qur'an and Sunnah and the expansion of Islam during some as a precedent in Islamic law and its own time and place

-This value of equality is not to be incorrect for or confused with similarity or stereotype. Islam teaches that in the view of Allah Almighty, all people are equal, but they are not necessarily indistinguishable.

-There are variances of capabilities, abilities, determinations, wealth and so on.

-Yet, none of these differences can by themselves found the status of lead of one man or race over another.

-The standard of man, his skin color, the amount of capital he has and the degree of respect he enjoys has no attitude on the personality of the individual as far as Allah is concerned.

-The only difference, which Allah identifies, is the difference in religiousness the only standard which Allah applies, is the standard of goodness and spiritual excellence.

- In the Quran, Allah Almighty Says (what means): *O mankind, indeed we have created you from male and female, and have made you into nations and tribes, that you may know one another. Indeed the most honored of you in the sight of Allah is the most righteous.* Indeed, Allah is Knowing and Acquainted (Quran, Al-Hujrat, 49:13) .

-This is to declare that in Islam, no nation is made to be above other nations or to rise above them.

-Man's value in the eyes of men and in the eyes of Allah is determined by the good he does, and by his respect to Allah.

-The differences of race, color or social status are only supplementary.

-They do not affect the true standing of man in the vision of Allah.

-Again, the value of equality is not simply a substance of constitutional rights or the agreement of nobles or condescending charity.

-It is an article of trust, which the Muslim takes seriously and to which the must follow honestly.

-The fundamentals of this Islamic value of equality are extremely deep-rooted in the arrangement of Islam. It stems from basic ideologies such as the following:

-All men are created by One and the Same Eternal God, the Supreme Lord of all.

-All mankind belong to the human race and share equally in the common parentage of Aadam (Adam) and Eve (Hawa).

-Allah is Just and Kind to all His creatures. He is not partial to any race, age or religion. The whole Universe is His Dominion and all people are His creatures.

-All people are born equal, in the sense that no one brings any possession with him; and they die equal in the sense that they take back nothing of their worldly belongings.

-Allah judges every person on the basis of his own merits and according to his own deeds.

-Allah has discussed on man, a title of honor and dignity.

- Those were some of the principles behind the value of equality in Islam. When this concept is fully utilized, it will leave no place for prejudice or harassments.
- And when this Great rule is fully applied, there will be no room for domination or conquest.
- Concepts of chosen and gentile peoples, words such as 'privileged' and 'condemned' races, words such as "social classes" and "citizens" will all become worthless and outdated.
- Prophet Muhammad SWT said: O mankind, your Lord is one and your father is one. You all descended from Aadam, and Aadam was created from earth.
- He is most honored among you in the sight of God who is most upright.
- No Arab is superior to a non-Arab, no colored person to a white person, or a white person to a colored person except by Taqwa (piety) (At-Tirmithi).
- Therefore, it would be improbable to declare the complete equality of human beings, although humans are essentially equal in rights, duties and accountability, and there is some degree of similarity in physical and mental behaviors, which enables them to understand and apply rules and laws.
- At the same time, it is understandable that there is a natural range among human beings in terms of qualities and abilities; therefore there will be limits in natural, common and political positions. Some of the limits are temporary, some permanent; some are rare, some regular.
- However, a control is specific to a particular situation. It may not be generalized to inequality in other rights.
- A person who is morally upright is not equal to a staff in terms of morality, but they may be equal otherwise.
- Nor is an intelligent person equal to a dull one, but they are equal in other spheres. In the same way, a woman is not indistinguishable to man in her characters, gifts and skills.

7. Al-amr bil maruf wa nahi an al-munkar

-Amongst the greatest responsibilities are amr-bil-Ma'roof (ordering for acknowledged virtues) and nahi anil munkar (forbidding from sin). Allah says: *"And there should be a group amongst you who invite towards good, order for acknowledged virtues, forbid from sin and these it is that are the successful ones"* (Quran, Al-Imran, 3:104).

-The Holy Prophet said: *"How will it be for you when your women will commit sins and your youth will transgress and you will not order for acknowledged virtues nor forbid from sin?"* It was said to him: *"Will that happen O messenger of Allah?"* Then he said: Yes. Then he said: *"How will it be for you when you order for sins and forbid from acknowledged virtues?"* Then it was said to him: *"O messenger of Allah! Will that happen?"* Then he said: *"Yes and worse than that how will it be for you when you perceive acknowledged virtue as sin and perceive sin as acknowledged virtue?"*

-Imam Sadiq said: Woe to the people who do not support the religion of Allah by enjoining good and forbidding evil (Sadiq)

-The expression 'amr bi al-ma'ruf wa-nahy an al-munkar' is a very important one.

-It is associated to J ihad, that is, doing one's highest to understand a aim.

-J ihad is not essentially war fought on the battlefield for which the specific Arabic and Quranic term is 'qital.' J ihad has a very wide meaning and states to striving for the cause of Allah Almighty to promote goodness and eliminate evil. A mujahid is a person who carries out J ihad or works hard for the cause of endorsing the values of the Glorious Quran.

-Thus, Amr bil ma'roof wa nahy an al-munkar which means ordering good and forbidding evil, is a J ihad related principle.

-It seeks to intelligently carry the benefits of Islam to the people and to inform them of the meaning of what devil do.

-The Quran calls Muslims the model community which requires to convey the Prophet message to entire humanity and to live the Quran, just as the Prophet did.

"Amr bil Ma'ruf wa Nahy an al Munkar" is an important Islamic duty, together believed by all Muslims. The difference is in the understanding of it.

-Some consider that it is enough to accomplish the duty by the "heart and tongue," which means one should support al-ma'ruf and oppose al-munkar in his heart and use his tongue to speak out for al-ma'ruf and against al-munkar.

-But there are some who justify taking up arms (if necessary) for the sake of fulfilling this duty.

MARRIAGE IN ISLAM

-Islam, unlike other religions is a strong advocate of marriage. There is no place for celibacy like, for example the Roman Catholic priests and nuns.

-The prophet has said "*there is no celibacy in Islam*".

-Marriage is a religious duty and is consequently a moral safeguard as well as a social necessity. Islam does not equal celibacy with high "taqwa" / "Iman".

The prophet has also said, "*Marriage is my tradition who so ever keeps away there from is not from amongst me*".

-Marriage acts as an outlet for sexual needs and regulate it so one does not become a slave to his/ her desires.

-It is a social necessity because through marriage, families are established and the family is the fundamental unit of our society. Furthermore, marriage is the only legitimate or halal way to indulge in intimacy between a man and a woman.

-Islam takes a middle of the road position to sexual relations , it neither condemns it like certain religions, nor does it allow it freely.

- Islam urges us to control and regulate our desires, whatever they may be so that we remain dignified and not become like animals.

The purpose of Marriage.

-The word "zawj" is used in the Qur'an to mean a pair or a mate. In general it usage

refers to marriage.

-The general purpose of marriage is that the sexes can provide company to one another, love to one another, procreate children and live in peace and tranquility to the commandments of Allah.

- Marriage serves as a means to emotional and sexual gratification and as a means of tension reduction.

- It is also a form of Ibadah because it is obeying Allah and his messenger - i.e. Marriage is seen as the only possible way for the sexes to unite.

-One could choose to live in sin, however by choosing marriage one is displaying obedience to Allah.

-Marriage is "mithaq" - a solemn covenant (agreement). It is not a matter which can be taken lightly. It should be entered into with total commitment and full knowledge of what it involves. It is not like buying a new dress where you can exchange it if you don't like it.

-Your partner should be your choice for life.

-One should be mature enough to understand the demands of marriage so that the union can be a **lasting one**.

Divorce in Islam

Causes of Divorce in Islam religion

-Islam tolerates divorce and separation of a husband and wife under specific conditions; however, Islam regards divorce as abhorrent and reprehensible.

-Islam holds divorce as an extremely ugly and vile act, which must be avoided within the bounds of possibility as it even rocks the very Throne of God.

-Even though it has not been forbidden, for various reasons, it is severely condemned. In order to prevent divorce, Islam campaigns against its causes, some of which are enumerated below:

-One influential factor for divorce is the disheartenment of a husband for his legitimate wife and his fondness and affection towards non-*mahram* women.

1. The chief instrument for this is lack of adequate *Hijab* among women and leering in men. When a man looks upon a woman who is more beautiful and attractive than his own wife he may become infatuated with her and become disheartened with his wife. Little by little he makes familial life bitter by finding faults, seeking excuses, and picking quarrels, which might ultimately lead to divorce.

-In order to keep this from happening, on the one hand, Islam enjoins women to observe *Hijab*, cover their attractions from men, and refrain from being alluring for anyone but their own husbands. On the other hand, Islam directs men to abstain from looking at, and joking and bantering with non-*mahram* women. If their eyes happen upon a non-*mahram* woman, they must not linger and immediately look away.

2. Another agent for divorce is indifference of spouses towards one other and apathy and lack of passion in fulfillment of the sexual needs of one another. Many divorces and deviations occur when a husband or wife is not sufficiently sexually gratified.

-To prevent this, Islam instructs women to wear their best clothes when at home, make themselves up according to their husbands' wishes, and display themselves with ardent fervor.

-Moreover, Islam charges men to observe cleanliness and personal hygiene, style themselves, and show a handsome and warm demeanor for their wives.

-Furthermore, Islam advises both women and men that when making love and performing sexual acts, they must not only think of their own pleasure and release but seek to give pleasure and gratification to their partner also.

3. A third catalyst for divorce is misconduct, discourteousness, carping, picking quarrels, and stubbornness in a husband, wife, or both. Statistics show that the prime reason for most divorces is behavior incompatibility of spouses.

-Islam strives to pre-empt these factors and strengthen the cornerstones of the holy institution of family by prescribing various rights and responsibilities for men and

women.

- In addition, it advises against selfishness, egocentricity, autocracy, and recalcitrance, and advocates tolerance, forgiveness, and resolving differences with reason, fairness and affection.

-The moral obligations of both women and men have been explicated in detail in various books on ethics, but some of these have been indicated in chapter five.

-Islam has also anticipated the need for a team of arbitrators to resolve the disputes of spouses and preclude divorce.

-This team consists of two mediators; one chosen by the wife's family, and one by the husband's. -They may be of the couple's family or unrelated.

CHRISTIANITY

Authority of the Bible

-For the record, we believe that all of the main denominations of Christianity are accepted and honored by God the Father.

-As we all know, the Christian faith has been divided up into many different denominations such as the Baptists, Catholics, Presbyterians, Methodists, Pentecostals, Charismatics, Episcopalians, Lutherans, etc.

-denominationalism is actually an offense against God, as He obviously would like to have all of His Body to be unified as one with Him, not being divided up into all of these different denominations.

-We only have one God and one Bible, but yet we have all of these different denominations. As a result of this big divide in the Body of Christ, we do not present to the rest of the world a perfectly unified Body.

-The Bible tells us that we will only know in part while we are all down here, so it should come as no surprise that there are going to be some major differences between some

of us on interpreting different parts of the Bible.

-As a result of many of these different interpretations of the Bible over the years, the Body of Christ has now been split up into all of these different denominations.

-But though the Body of Christ has now been split up into all of these different denominations, this should still not prevent us in making sure that all of these different denominations stay true and loyal to the basic tenets of the Christian faith.

-We believe that as long as all of these different denominations stay true and loyal to the basic tenets of the Christian faith, that God will still continue to work with all of them.

-But if any one of them ever start to get off into any serious error on any one of these basic tenets, they could then get themselves into serious trouble with the Lord, as I do not believe there is any slack with the Lord on any of these basic fundamental tenets.

Relationship between old and new testament

-The relationship between the Old Testament and the New Testament reflects both the continuity and discontinuity between the Christian and Israelite faiths.

-Christians believe God had one plan for salvation that was revealed first to the Israelites and then to all peoples through Jesus Christ.

-The New Testament and Old Testament, then, tell one ongoing story of salvation. At the same time, the authors of the New Testament were proposing something radically new: Jesus' fulfillment of the Israelites' hope in God's promises.

-For the New Testament writers, the Old Testament was holy scripture.

-To tell the story of Jesus, those authors relied largely on the vocabulary and methods of reading scripture that already existed in the Jewish world.

-According to one scholarly estimate, the New Testament has more than 4,000 references to the Old Testament; thus the books of the Old Testament have been important for Christians and remain, in the words of the Second Vatican Council's *Dei Verbum* (Dogmatic Constitution on Divine Revelation), "permanently valuable" because

they were “written under divine inspiration.”

-The Old Testament can be viewed more easily through historical and prophetic eyes, and is a necessary preface to the content of the New Testament that follows.

-The Old Testament begins with Creation and follows with a covenant relationship theme between God and humans, albeit a select and pioneering group, beginning with Abraham and on through to the ancient Israelites.

-Woven throughout the Old Testament narrative of people, places and historical events is the divine and sovereign first cause of “ONE GOD” and His direct influence on the lives of his people in this world.

-This gives rise to those men of God, such as David, Isaiah and Ezekiel, having experienced a level of prophetic utterance that spoke not only to the ancient Israelites immediate life situation, but also of realities, events and things far into the future.

-Examples of this are the messianic prophecies beginning in the Garden of Eden account, in Moses’ writings and on through the prophets, such as Isaiah, predicting the Messiah.

Concept of sin

What Is Sin - A Biblical Perspective

-Sin is mentioned hundreds of times in the Bible, starting with the "original" sin when Adam and Eve ate of the tree of knowledge.

-Often it seems as if sin is simply the violation of any of God's laws, including the Ten Commandments.

-Paul, however, puts this in perspective in Romans 3:20, when he says, *"Therefore no one will be declared righteous in His sight by observing the law; rather, through the law we become conscious of sin."*

-God wanted us to recognize our sins.

-Even those who have not murdered or committed adultery will find themselves convicted of lying, or of worshipping false idols like wealth or power ahead of God.

-Tragically, sin in any amount will distance us from God.

"Surely the arm of the LORD is not too short to save, nor His ear too dull to hear," says Isaiah 59:1-2. "But your iniquities have separated you from your God; your sins have hidden His face from you, so that He will not hear."

-We must resist the temptation to act as if we are righteous, especially by leaning on our good works.

"If we claim to be without sin, we deceive ourselves and the truth is not in us. If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just and will forgive us our sins and purify us from all unrighteousness. If we claim we have not sinned, we make him out to be a liar and his word has no place in our lives" (1 John 1:8-10).

Sin As A Call to Repentance

-The good news in all of this is that, once we recognize ourselves as sinners, we need only to repent and embrace Jesus to be forgiven.

-Jesus can forgive us because he died and rose again three days later in victory over sin and death.

-The Apostle Paul refers to this process of recognizing sin and being responsible for it as "godly sorrow."

"Godly sorrow brings repentance that leads to salvation and leaves no regret, but

worldly sorrow brings death," Paul writes in 2 Corinthians 7:10-11. "See what this godly sorrow has produced in you: what earnestness, what eagerness to clear yourselves, what indignation, what alarm, what longing, what concern, what readiness to see justice done. At every point you have proved yourselves to be innocent in this matter."

SALVATION IN CHRISTIANITY

Christian Beliefs about Salvation

Need for Salvation: Sin and Death

- In Christianity, salvation is made possible by the sacrificial death of Jesus Christ by crucifixion 2,000 years ago.
- The word atonement, one of the few theological words of English origin, is used to describe this concept.
- The verb "atone" derives from the adverb "at one," and therefore means "to reconcile."
- According to many Christian teachings, ascent into heaven is only possible through salvation.
- Salvation is not just an important concept in Christianity.
- To the devout Christian, it is actually the desired outcome to be gained from living a pious Christian life. In Christianity, salvation means eternal life after death, and freedom from sin and the consequences of sin.
- The salvation of a soul spares that soul the wrath of God's judgment and an afterlife of eternal damnation.
- Many Christian denominations teach that the reward for salvation is eternal life after death and a reprieve from the harsh judgment of God for earthly sins.
- This is where the concept of heaven comes in.
- Heaven is understood by most mainstream Christians to be the holy place where the souls of saved Christians go after death. In heaven, Christians believe there is no sin,

illness, or suffering.

-Those souls that are admitted to Heaven are in the constant presence of God and Jesus Christ, which inspires many Christians to strive for salvation and a life of piety.

-“salvation” concerns an eternal, spiritual deliverance.

-When Paul told the Philippian jailer what he must do to be saved, he was referring to the jailer’s eternal destiny (Acts 16:30-31).

-Jesus equated being saved with entering the kingdom of God (Matthew 19:24-25)

CONCEPT OF THE HOLY SPIRIT.

Eschatology Definition

Eschatology is the branch of Christian theology dealing with the biblical study of end times prophecies and the events of the last days.

Some of these events include the Rapture, the Second Coming of Christ, the Tribulation, the Millennial Kingdom and the Future Judgments. The primary books of the Bible pertaining to end times prophecy are the book of Daniel, the book of Ezekiel and the book of Revelation.

Though a challenging area of study, Eschatology helps believers understand the prophetic passages of Scripture and how to live the Christian life in preparation for the end times.

Importance of Eschatology

1. First, prophecy makes up a great amount of the biblical text.

-Studies have shown that 27 percent of the Bible is prophetic in nature.

2. Second, Eschatology proves the divine power of God.

-For example, when the Bible speaks of one who would be born of a virgin (Isaiah 7:14)

named Emmanuel (meaning "God with us") and the prophecy is specifically fulfilled more than six hundred years later in Jesus, it affirms the ability of God to reveal the supernatural.

3. Third, prophecy motivates Christians to live holy lives, knowing that many of the Bible's as-yet unfulfilled prophecies speak of the believer's future home with the Lord.

BIRTH NARRATIVES OF JESUS

BIRTH NARRATIVES ACCORDING TO MATTHEW

- Matthew traces the genealogy of Jesus to Abraham's son of David, son of Abraham" which implies that Jesus emerged from Israel and fulfill the OT of the Messianic King.

The Virgin Conception

- For some, the miraculous claim of the virgin conception of Jesus disqualifies the Gospel accounts as a reliable history
- Christopher Hitchens regularly referred to the virgin conception as a clear example of the unreasonable nature of the gospel.
- The virgin conception according to Hitchens is obviously irrational and it disqualifies the story of Jesus before it even begins.
- The virgin birth of Jesus is the belief that Jesus was conceived in the womb of his mother Mary by the Holy Spirit and born while Mary was yet a virgin 1:18-25.
- The virgin birth was universally accepted by Christian tradition in the 2nd Century.
- The virgin conception is a controversial subject among modern scholars.
- It is clear in the account of Matthew that Joseph was not the biological father of Jesus.
- The tradition preserved in Matt 1:22-23 connects Jesus's virgin birth with Isaiah 7:14.
- The passages in both Matthew and Luke are believed to be authentic, with no evidence

at all that they were later additions to the text.

- Today some scholars regard the doctrine of Jesus' virgin birth as simply a legendary development of the early church. The story is said to be a myth and not history.
- Such Scholars really believe that miracles are impossible, but no amount of evidence can convince them that it actually happened.

VIEWING BY THE MAGI

- Matthew was the only one of the four canonical gospels to mention the magi
- Magi are said to be the first religious figures to worship Jesus.
- They came from the East to worship the Christ "born the king of the Jews"
- The account does not mention the number of people "they" or "the magi" but the three gifts led to the assumption that there were three men.
- The Magi acknowledged Jesus as the promised king.
- The narrative then underscores the truth that Jesus is the Promised King.
- The fact that the Magi worshipped him shows that the child was more than just somebody hence Jesus was far more than a future king.
- The gifts that were presented were symbolic ege Gold was a gift for the King and in the OT gold was a proper setting for the sanctuary where God dwelt among his people, Myrrh symbolizing the preparation for his suffering.

The Herodian Genocide

a. The Massacre of the children of Bethlehem.

- Herod ordered the execution of all young male children in the vicinity of Bethlehem, so as to avoid the loss of his throne to a newborn King of the Jews whose birth had been announced to him by the Magi.
- In typical Matthean style, it is understood as a fulfillment of the OT prophecy which

was spoken through the prophet J eremiah saying “A voice is heard in Ramah, mourning and great weeping, Rachel weeping for her children and refusing to be comforted because her children are more “ J er 2:16-18

- The account of the Massacre is only found in the gospel of Matthew.
- According to Michael Grant, Matthew’s story of the Massacre of the innocence by Herod the Great was a myth allegedly fulfilling a prophecy by J eremiah.
- When the life of Herod is examined, the massacre event is very consistent with his behaviour, character and actions so this is pointing to the fact that it did happen.

b. The Flight to Egypt

- According to J immy Dunn, The Holy Family’s Flight to Egypt was really mentioned briefly in the second chapter of the Gospel of Matthew.
- The family was able to avoid the massacre by fleeing to Egypt, where they remained until an angel told J oseph that Herod died.
- Matthew tells the event as the fulfillment of the words spoken by God to the prophet Hosea “Out of Egypt have I called my son” Hosea 11:1’
- Matthew understood these words as foretelling the coming of the Messiah.

c. The return of the holy family to Nazareth

- After Herod died, an Angel of the Lord appeared in a dream to J oseph in Egypt and instructed him to take the child and his mother to the land of Israel.
- He took the child and his mother and went to the land of Israel but when he heard that Archelaus was reigning in J udea in place of his father Herod, he was afraid to go there.
- He withdrew to the district of galilee and he went and settled in a town called Nazareth.
- This was said to be a fulfillment of what was said through prophets, that he would be called a Nazarene.

Birth Narratives according to Luke.

- All narratives are unique except the genealogy.

1. Promise to Zechariah

- Unique to Luke.
- Has theological interest in outcasts and also interest in women.
- Depicts interest in prayer, joy and Holy Spirit.

2. Announcement to Mary 1:26-38.

- Jesus is divine as he is a product of the Holy Spirit.
- Jewishness ie Jesus descendent of David.
- Interest in women ie mentioning of Mary.
- Interest in the Holy Spirit.

3. Mary's Visit to Elizabeth. (1:39-45)

- Interest in women.
- Interest in the Holy Spirit.

4. Magnificat (a Song of Praise by Mary (1:46-56)

- Interest in women, joy and outcasts
- Song derived from the Song of Hannah.
- Theme of Universalism.

5. The Birth of John the Baptist 1:57-66.

- Interest in joy.

- Jewishness is shown by circumcision of John the Baptist on the 8th day.

6. Benedictus 1:67-79(Zachariah's song of praise)

- Interest in the Holy Spirit cause he spoke while under the Holy spirit.
- Peculiar to Luke.
- Interest in Joy

7. The birth of Jesus Christ (2:1-7)

- Unique to Luke.
- Interest in women for Mary continues to be the main character.
- Interest in the poor/ outcasts coz Jesus was laid in a manger which was a feeding through feeding trough for domesticated animals.

8. Announcement of Jesus's birth to the shepherds 2:8-14.

- Interest in the outcasts coz of the shepherds and also interest in joy to the shepherds.
- Interest in universalism.
- "A savior who is Christ" shows the divinity and Christology of Jesus.
- "Praising God" shows the interest in joy.

9. Visit by shepherds to Mary and Joseph (2:15-20).

- Interest in joy for the shepherds returned glorifying and praising God.
- Interest in the poor for Jesus was laid in a manger and outcasts.

10. Presentation of Jesus in the Temple 2:22-40.

- Mary and Joseph as Jewish parents prepared for Jewish customs for Luke had interest in Jews eg circumcision.
- For every male who opens a womb was called Holy and stayed in the Temple but Mary and Joseph had to bring him back home so they had to buy him and take him

home.

- A pair of turtle doves was to be offered as an offering of a poor person i.e. those who couldn't afford the lamb would offer turtle doves.

- This shows interest in the poor.

- This shows that Luke was sharing the humble beginning of Jesus.

- Simeon was filled with the Holy Spirit which shows interest in the Holy Spirit.

- This is unique to Luke and following Jewish customs

- Interest in Universalism.

11. Song of Simeon 2:32-40.

- Simeon was filled with the Holy Spirit i.e. interest in the Holy Spirit.

- Unique to Luke.

- Interest in Universalism, 4:2-32.

- Shows gentiles in mind and its Simeon's song of praise "A light to the Gentiles"

- Luke 2:36- the prophetess Anna which shows interest in women and was a widow till she was 84yrs which shows interest in the poor and prayer too

- Shows interest in Joy and outcasts.

The virgin birth of Jesus

- Jesus was born of a virgin.

- This is a unique glory.

- Of the billions of humans who have lived throughout history, only one person entered the world in this way.

- There is only one mediator between God and man (1 Timothy 2:5), and there is only

one human who was virgin born.

-J esus' distinctive birth isn't a myth nor merely a random fact from the Gospels. It is a special honor conferred only on the Son of God.

-And it is full of significance for knowing the person of J esus and the God who has revealed himself in him.

Supernatural, Not Mythical

-Matthew and Luke wrote the authoritative accounts.

-Neither was likely to be gullible in the least. Matthew was a former tax-collector.

-Luke was a doctor.

-True—medicine has come a long way in twenty centuries, but it isn't a recent discovery that virgins don't have babies.

-From the very beginning of J esus' human life, his eternal Father set him apart as exceptional.

-The Gospel writers didn't concoct a myth.

-Luke even consulted with J esus' mother who confirmed that J esus' birth was supernatural.

Why the Virgin Birth?

What is the significance of the virgin birth?

- To begin with, it highlights the supernatural. On one end of J esus' life lies his supernatural conception and birth; on the other, his supernatural resurrection and his ascension to God's right hand. J esus' authenticity was attested to by the supernatural working of his Father.

-Secondly, the virgin birth shows that humanity needs redeeming that it can't bring about for itself. The fact that the human race couldn't produce its own redeemer implies that its sin and guilt are profound and that its savior must come from outside.

-Thirdly, in the virgin birth, God's initiative is on display. The angel didn't ask Mary about her willingness. He announced, "Behold, you will conceive in your womb and bear a son, and you shall call his name Jesus" (Luke 1:31). God didn't ask Mary for permission. He acted—gently but decisively—to save his people from their sins (Matthew 1:21).

-Finally, this virgin birth hints at the fully human and fully divine natures united in Jesus' one person. The entry of the eternal Word into the world didn't have to happen this way. But it did. Wayne Grudem writes,

-God, in his wisdom, ordained a combination of human and divine influence in the birth of Christ, so that his full humanity would be evident to us from the fact of his ordinary human birth from a human mother, and his full deity would be evident from the fact of his conception in Mary's womb by the powerful work of the Holy Spirit.

BAPTISM OF JESUS

-The **baptism of Jesus** is described in the gospels of Matthew, Mark and Luke. John's gospel does not directly describe Jesus' baptism.

-Most modern theologians view the baptism of Jesus by John the Baptist as a historical event to which a high degree of certainty can be assigned.

-Along with the crucifixion of Jesus, most biblical scholars view it as one of the two historically certain facts about him, and often use it as the starting point for the study of the historical Jesus.

-The baptism is one of the five major milestones in the gospel narrative of the life of Jesus, the others being the Transfiguration, Crucifixion, Resurrection, and Ascension.

- Most Christian denominations view the baptism of Jesus as an important event and a basis for the Christian rite of baptism.

Why was Jesus Baptized

- The baptism therefore marked the point at which Jesus publicly commits himself to the role for which he had been destined at birth.

- The reason why John had people baptized was to show that they had changed their minds (repented)

- Jesus' baptism is said to be a mark to the beginning of his ministry and by baptizing Jesus, John was declaring to all that Jesus was the one they had been waiting for, the son of God, the one he had predicted would baptize with holy spirit and fire.

JESUS' PARABLES

- A *parable* is a story about a familiar subject to teach an important moral lesson.

- A parable can also be defined as a short and simple story that illustrates a deep and important message.

- The root meaning of the word parable means a placing side by side for the sake of comparison.

- The Gospel writer generally identifies a narrative with a spiritual meaning by specifically calling the lesson parable.

- Parables were Jesus' favorite way of teaching
- Jesus's parables had double meaning, first being the literal meaning which is apparent to anyone who has experience with the subject matter and beyond the literal meaning lies a deeper meaning which is the surface lesson about God's truth and his Kingdom eg the parable of the leaven Matthew 13:33.
- Jesus' parables often involve an element of surprise or an unexpected twist.

- At times the Gospel writer begins the story with the word like, as "The Kingdom of Heaven is *like* a landowner who went out at dawn to hire laborers for his vineyard" (Matthew 20:1). Or Jesus may give an example from everyday life to convey a spiritual truth, such as the Parable of the Good Samaritan to teach love and mercy, or the Parable of the Friend at Midnight to teach persistence in prayer.

- A parable envisions the whole narrative to generate the spiritual message, whereas a

proverb, metaphor, simile, or figure of speech focuses generally on a word, phrase or sentence.

-The Parables of Jesus are recorded in the Synoptic Gospels of Matthew, Mark, and Luke.

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Why did Jesus teach in Parables?

1. Jesus spoke in parables so that ordinary people would not understand, because by understanding, their sins would have been forgiven.
2. To separate truth seekers from curiosity seekers.
3. To appeal to the hearers' sense of justice before they realized the parable applied to them eg Matthew 21:33-44 the Parable of the wicked vine-dressers.
4. To illustrate the spiritual principles in much the same way parables and analogies are used.
5. To reveal the heavenly truths to just a selected group of people whose hearts were open and receptive to those truths.

-Some parables are common to all three Synoptic Gospels, such as the Parable of the Sower (Matthew 13:3-23, Mark 4:2-20, and Luke 8:4-15).

-Matthew relates ten Parables on the Kingdom of Heaven, seven of which occur in Chapter 13 and are central to his Gospel. -Examples of parables unique to Matthew are the Weeds Among the Wheat (Matthew 13:24-30), the Unforgiving Servant (18:23-35), the Laborers in the Vineyard (20:1-16), the Two Sons (21:28-32), and the Ten Virgins (25:1-13). Mark has only one unique Parable, the Growing Seed (Mark 4:26-29).

- Several Parables are unique to Luke, such as the Parables of the Good Samaritan

(Luke 10:25-37), the Friend at Midnight (11:5-13), the Rich Fool (12:13-21), the Barren Fig Tree (13:6-9), the Invited Guests (14:7-14), the Lost Coin (15:8-10), the Prodigal Son (15:11-32), Lazarus and the Rich Man (16:19-31), the Persistent Widow (18:1-8), and the Pharisee and the Tax Collector (18:9-14).

MIRACLES OF JESUS

-Jesus of Nazareth performed many **miracles**, demonstrating his power over nature and spirits, and thus confirming that the Kingdom of God is at hand (Mark 1:15). *"Come, follow me, and I will make you fishers of men"* (Matthew 4:19).

-Through the above miracle, Jesus recruited his first four Apostles - Peter, his brother Andrew, and James and John.

-In a physical miracle, such as making the blind see, or walking on water, or calming a storm, the laws of the universe are suspended through divine intervention.

-In a moral miracle, such as forgiveness of sins or driving out demons, the blessing of Jesus purifies the soul.

-In Mark 2:1-12, Jesus performed a physical miracle, healing the paralytic, to demonstrate a moral miracle, the forgiveness of sins.

-Only three miracles appear in all four Gospels - his own Resurrection (Matthew 28, Mark 16, Luke 24, and John 20), the greatest miracle of them all; the feeding of the 5000 through the multiplication of the loaves and fish, found in Matthew 14:13-21, Mark 6:30-44, Luke 9:10-17, and John 6:1-14; and, while different individuals are involved (see chart), Jesus heals the blind (Matthew 9:27-31, Mark 8:22-26, Luke 18:35-43, and John 9).

-The miracle stories are an integral part of the Gospel narrative, as in the Gospel of Mark, where nearly half of Mark's account of the public ministry of Jesus (Chapters 1-10) describes miracles.

-The ministry of Jesus is centered on the establishment of God's imminent Kingdom, which ended the dominion of the evil one over the world, present ever since sin and death entered mankind.

-The miracles were Jesus' chief weapon in the struggle with evil (Mark 3:22-27), the most direct being the exorcism of demons, which defeated the power of evil and liberated humanity.

-That is why a miracle is an act of power in the Synoptic Gospels.

-The Gospels record twelve miracles in Capernaum, more than anywhere else in the Holy Land.

-What is striking is that Jesus performs those miracles that, referring to Isaiah 29:18-19 and 35:3-6, were signs of the **Messiah**.

-John the Baptist sent his disciples to ask Jesus or Yeshua - *"Are you the one who is to come, or should we expect another?"*

-Jesus reassures John and his disciples by naming the miracles of the Messiah: *"the blind receive their sight, the lame walk, the lepers are cleansed, the deaf hear, the dead are raised, and the poor have good news preached to them"* (Matthew 11:3-5).

-Jesus not only heals the leper but also instructs the leper to show himself to the priest in observance of Leviticus 13-14 (Matthew 8:1-4).

-Jesus Christ raised three from the dead: the daughter of Jairus the synagogue official (Mark 5:22-24, 35-43), the son of the widow of Nain (Luke 7:11-17), and Lazarus on the fourth day (John 11).

-The symbolic element of the miracle becomes primary in the Gospel of John.

-For example, in John 9, the interest in giving sight to the man born blind is not just the gift of sight, but in his coming to the spiritual insight of faith, an insight made possible by Jesus, the Light of the world.

-The Gospel of J ohn enumerates seven signs of J esus: he turns water into wine at the wedding feast of Cana (2:1-12); the healing of an official's son in Capernaum (4:43-54); the healing of a paralytic on the sabbath by the pool at Bethes da in J erusalem (5:1-47); the feeding of the five thous and (6:1-14) before the Bread of Life discourse; walking on water (6:16-21); the healing of a man born blind (9:1-41); and the raising of Lazarus (11:1-57).

-J ohn also records three appearances of Christ to his disciples following his Resurrection.

-The miracles of the Multiplication of the Loaves and Fish and the Wedding Feast of Cana serve as a prelude to the miracle of the Institution of the Eucharist at the Last Supper of our Lord, *and* the giving of Communion in our Churches throughout the world!

-The third millennium is more receptive to miracles as compared to the skepticism of the post-Enlightenment.

-Case records of inexplicable cures from cancer, the healings of Guadalupe, Mexico, Lourdes, France, and Fatima, Portugal, and reports of near-death experiences have produced an openness to the miraculous.

-While Christ J esus performed innumerable healings and exorcisms (Matthew 8:16-17, Mark 1:32-34, Luke 6:17-19), the following chart lists specific miracles of J esus Christ during his public ministry, before his Resurrection:

Importance of J esus' miracles

- To show the divine nature of J esus.
- To show J esus' power over nature.
- To Show J esus's power over death
- To Show J esus's power to forgive sins.

- To Show J esus' power over demons.
- To show the universalism of J esus.

KINGDOM OF GOD.

- This is not a dominant theme in Mark's gospel as compared to Matt and Luke.
- In 1:14, the Kingdom is mentioned as a present reality {realized eschatology} which has already come.
- The ministry of J esus is the inauguration of the kingdom through exorcism eg Demoniac at Capernaum, healing of the paralysed, fellowship with sinners, feeding of the hungry, calling of the disciples etc

The kingdom as a future reality

- Mark also portrays the kingdom as a future reality ie it was something still to come 10:23-25.
- The kingdom is also mentioned at the last supper {14:25}.
- 15:43, J oseph of Arimathea is described as a man awaiting the kingdom.
- 13:26-32 the kingdom is associated with judgment.
- As the kingdom is a future reality, there is a call for watchfulness 13:33.
- The kingdom is portrayed as a mystery 4:11.
- The kingdom is portrayed as starting small but grows into a huge harvest 4:3-9.
- Parable of the mastered seed shows the kingdom as a present a future reality.

RESURRECTION OF J ESUS

Resurrection of Jesus: Why It's Important!

- Crucifixion was important as it earmarked the salvation of the saints.
- If Jesus was not crucified there was not going to be peace prevailing after the account of the arrest and trial.
- The crucifixion was a confirmation that Jesus was indeed a Messiah who had died for the sins of the people.
- The death and Resurrection account was so central in the revival of the faith within the early church.
- The resurrection of Jesus is the foundation of the Christian faith.
- To prove that Jesus' death was a ransom for sinners otherwise Jesus was sinless.
- The resurrection account was so central in the revival of the faith within the early church.
- The faith and belief was mainly foundationed on the hope that often the resurrection account Jesus was going come back for the second time and take those who would have repented into the Kingdom of Heaven.

-In Paul's letter to the Corinthians, he declares:

"And if Christ be not risen, then is our preaching vain, and your faith is also vain. Yea, and we are found false witnesses of God; because we have testified of God that He raised up Christ: whom He raised not up, if so be that the dead rise not." (1 Corinthians 15:14-15).

"And if Christ be not raised, your faith is vain; ye are yet in your sins." (1 Corinthians 15:17). As it turns out, no legitimate scholar or religion today denies that Jesus was a historical figure who walked the earth approximately 2,000 years ago, was a great teacher and miracle worker, and who died on a cross for the crime of blasphemy.

Therefore, the only legitimate dispute is whether J esus was the Son of God who was resurrected from the dead after His crucifixion.

Resurrection of J esus: Eyewitness Testimonies

- The resurrection of J esus is challenged today on evidentiary grounds.
- Therefore, to be fair, the evidence should be judged like any other historical event.
- Based on standard rules of evidence, consistent eye-witness testimony from multiple credible witnesses would be considered the strongest form of evidence available to a litigant.
- Therefore, if we find such testimony present in credible accounts of the historical record of Christ's resurrection, we have satisfied a major evidentiary challenge under traditional rules.
- In fact, they are multiple eye-witness testimonies regarding the resurrection of J esus. In 1 Corinthians 15:3-6, Paul established the following:

“For I delivered unto you first of all that which I also received, how that Christ died for our sins according to the scriptures; And that He was buried, and that He rose again the third day according to the scriptures: And that He was seen of Cephas, then of the twelve: After that, He was seen of above five hundred brethren at once; of whom the greater part remain unto this present, but some are fallen asleep.”

Resurrection of J esus: More Eye-witness Accounts.

- The resurrection of J esus was also declared in numerous other accounts, including the appearance of J esus to Mary Magdalene (J ohn 20:10-18), to other women (Matthew 28:8-10), to Cleopas and his companion (Luke 24:13-32), to eleven disciples and others (Luke 24:33-49), to ten apostles and others (excluding Thomas) (J ohn 20:19-23), to the apostles (including Thomas) (J ohn 20:26-30), to seven apostles (J ohn

21:1-14), to the disciples (Matthew 28:16-20), and to the apostles on the Mount of Olives (Luke 24:50-52 and Acts 1:4-9).

-The ultimate test of credibility for these eye-witnesses was that many of them faced martyrdom for their eye-witness testimony. This is dramatic! These witnesses knew the truth.

-What could they possibly gain by dying for a known lie?

-The evidence speaks for itself, these weren't just religious faithful dying for a religious belief, these were followers of Jesus Christ dying for a historical event

– His resurrection that established Him as the Son of God.

Who was responsible for Jesus' death?

- The question on who was responsible for Jesus's death has remained a subject of debate if not controversy as a lot ink has been spilled on the scholarly desk by the New Testament caim from both angles of analysis.
- Through internal biblical exegesis that is internally there are two groups of people believed to be responsible for Jesus' death that are the Romans and Jews.
- Internationally, Jews and Romans are inevitably revealed to have been responsible for Jesus' death.
- Conventional wisdom has led some modern scholars to believe and assume that the Jews were responsible for the death since there were always in conflict with him.
- The Jews coheres and made the Romans believe that Jesus was a threat and hence deserved death.
- Pilate found Jesus innocent and wanted to free him but the Jews insisted and advocated for his death.
- With failure of the internal exegesis to indicate the exact people responsible for Jesus'

death. Ancient and modern scholars had set the ball rolling.

- According to **Babylonian Talmud** J esus was hanged because he practiced sorcery and was leading the people astray so the J ews gave them 40 days to come and plead with them for that accusation but he failed to report and in reciprocation he was hanged on the cross.
- In 1940, there had been a shift of the responsibility from the J ew to the Romans.
- J esus' death was a result of Roman method of eliminating people hence one may not deny the idea of the Romans being given responsibility of J esus' death.
- Brandon believes that the Romans killed J esus because of his association with the zealot movement which was a threat to the Roman Gvt because they were regarded as terrorists hence the Romans might be responsible for J esus's death.
- Romans felt some dangers that J esus would do an uprising against them.
- The character of the Apostle Peter who cut off the ear of the high priest slave at gethsemane posed a threat to J esus's life.
- The sons of Zebedia, J ames and J ohn were given the name Boarnage which means (sons of thunder) made the Romans to feel threatened.
- According to Brendon, the message of J esus on the eschatological discourse emphasized on another Kingdom to come which was in turn a threat to the existing Kingdom hence the Romans had a reason to kill J esus.
- The forerunner and pre-cussor of J esus, J ohn the Baptist was known as a radical revolutionist who was killed on political grounds posed a threat to J esus's life.
- Actions of J esus eg on Luke 22:35 were here told his disciples to have swords made the Romans unhappy with the movement.
- Besides the J ews and Romans, J esus himself triggered for his own death.

CHRISTIANITY ON HEALTH AND ILLNESS

- The history of Christianity has witnessed an active debate about proper attitudes towards suffering, pain, and death, and how best to confront human illness and frailty.
- The theological notion of Jesus' suffering and death on the cross is viewed by some as a redemptive valuation of suffering. In this view, some Christians argue that pain and hardship has a broader value and can have a potentially transformative affect on the religious adherent.
- Others emphasize Jesus' healing ministry and his compassion for the blind, the sick, and the lame. In a much-cited panorama of the Last Judgment, Jesus called on his followers to show the same empathy to others (Matthew 25:31-46).
- Efforts to link these two strands in Christian reflection and experience—Jesus' willingness to suffer and die and his compassion and healing—have traditionally been acknowledged as the inevitability of suffering combined with a determination to alleviate it, whenever possible, through the medical arts.
- The experience of suffering can have a redemptive dimension; it can bring individuals closer to a God who suffered with and for them on the cross.
- At the same time, Christians are called to embrace science and its biomedical applications in order to prevent and alleviate unnecessary suffering, whenever possible, while also respecting the sanctity of human life.

CHRISTIANITY AND POLITICS

- The relationship between **Christianity and politics** is a historically complex subject and a frequent source of disagreement throughout the history of Christianity, as well as in modern politics between the Christian right and Christian left.
- There have been a wide variety of ways in which thinkers have conceived of the relationship between Christianity and politics, with many arguing that Christianity directly supports a particular political ideology or philosophy.
- Along these lines, various thinkers have argued for Christian communism, Christian

socialism, Christian anarchism, Christian libertarianism, or Christian democracy.

-Others believe that Christians should have little interest or participation in politics or government'

-The Hebrew Bible contains a complex chronicle of the Kings of Israel and Judah, written over the course of many generations by authors whose relationships and intimacy with the rulers of the several kingdoms fluctuated widely in both intimacy and respect.

-Some historical passages of the Hebrew Bible contain intimate portrayals of the inner workings of the royal households of Saul, David and Solomon.

-The accounts of subsequent monarchs are frequently more distanced and less detailed and frequently begin with the judgment that the monarch "did evil in the sight of the Lord".

-The Christian New Testament instead begins with the story of Jesus, crucified as a criminal who had offended both the Jewish priesthood and the Roman imperial authorities.

-At least to outward appearances, Jesus was at the periphery of political life and power in the Roman province of Judea.

-Nevertheless, a number of political currents appear in New Testament writings.

-Early Christians were described by Celsus as those who refused military service and would not accept public office, nor assume any responsibility for the governing of cities.

-Origen confirms this description and adds that Christians do more for the good of the empire by forming an "army of piety" that prays for the well-being of the emperor and the safety of the empire.

-It has been argued that Christianity made a significant positive contribution to the development of modern democracy

-For Christians above all men are not permitted forcibly to correct the failings of those

who sin.

-Secular judges indeed, when they have captured malefactors under the law, show their authority to be great, and prevent them even against their will from following their own devices: but in our case the wrong-doer must be made better, not by force, but by persuasion.

- For neither has authority of this kind for the restraint of sinners been given us by law, nor, if it had been given, should we have any field for the exercise of our power, inasmuch as God rewards those who abstain from evil by their own choice, not of necessity.

-Consequently much skill is required that our patients may be induced to submit willingly to the treatment prescribed by the physicians, and not only this, but that they may be grateful also for the cure.

- For if any one when he is bound becomes restive (which it is in his power to be), he makes the mischief worse; and if he should pay no heed to the words which cut like steel, he inflicts another wound by means of this contempt, and the intention to heal only becomes the occasion of a worse disorder.

-For it is not possible for any one to cure a man by compulsion against his will.

ROLE OF WOMEN IN CHRISTIANITY.

-Although women have traditionally fulfilled supportive roles in serving the church and gained their greatest joy and sense of accomplishment from being wives and mothers, the feminist movement has successfully influenced many women to abandon these divinely ordained roles.

-Unfortunately, this movement has made headway even in the church, creating chaos and confusion regarding the role of women both in ministry and in the home.

-Only in Scripture can God's intended design for women be found.

The Old Testament and Women

-In the creation account of Genesis 1, God's first word on the subject of men and

women is that they were equally created in the image of God (v. 27).

- Neither received more of the image of God than the other. So the Bible begins with the equality of the sexes.

- As persons, as spiritual beings standing before God, men and women are absolutely equal.

- Despite this equality, there is in Genesis 2 a more detailed account of the creation of the two human beings that reveals differences in their God-given functions and responsibilities.

- God did not create the man and the woman at the same time, but rather He created Adam first and Eve later for the specific purpose of being Adam's helper.

- Eve was equal to Adam, but she was given the role and duty of submitting to him. Although the word "helper" carries very positive connotations—even being used of God Himself as the helper of Israel (Deut. 33:7; Ps. 33:20)—it still describes someone in a relationship of service to another.

- The responsibility of wives to submit to their husbands, then, was part of the plan from creation, even before the curse.

- The first books of the Bible establish both the equality of men and women and also the support role of the wife (see Exod. 21:15, 17, 28–31; Num. 5:19–20, 29; 6:2; 30:1–16).

- Adam and Eve's disobedience to God's command resulted in certain consequences (Gen. 3:16–19).

- For the woman, God pronounced a curse that included multiplied pain in childbirth and tension in the authority-submission relationship of husband and wife.

- Genesis 3:16 says the woman's "desire" will be for her husband but he shall "rule" over her.

- In Genesis 4:7 the author uses the same word "desire" to mean "excessive control over."

-Thus, the curse in Genesis 3:16 refers to a new desire on the part of the woman to exercise control over her husband—but he will in fact oppressively rule and exert authority over her.

-The result of the Fall on marriage through history has been an ongoing struggle between the sexes, with women seeking control and men seeking dominance.

-Throughout the Old Testament, women were active in the religious life of Israel, but generally they were not leaders.

-Women like Deborah (Judges 4) were clearly the exception and not the rule. There was no woman with an ongoing prophetic ministry.

-No woman was a priest.

-No queen ever ruled Israel.

-No woman wrote an Old Testament (or New Testament) book.

-Isaiah 3:12 indicates that God allowed women to rule as part of His judgment on the sinning nation.

Jesus and Women

-In the midst of the Greek, Roman, and Jewish cultures, which viewed women almost on the level of possessions, Jesus showed love and respect for women.

-Though Jewish rabbis did not teach women and the Jewish Talmud said it was better to burn the Torah than to teach it to a woman, Jesus never took the position that women, by their very nature, could not understand spiritual or theological truth.

-He not only included them in His audiences but also used illustrations and images that would be familiar to them (Matt. 13:33; 22:1–2; 24:41; Luke 15:8–10) and specifically applied His teaching to them (Matt. 10:34ff.).

-To the Samaritan woman at the well (John 4), He revealed that He was the Messiah and discussed with her topics such as eternal life and the nature of true worship.

-He also taught Mary and, when admonished by Martha, pointed out the priority of

learning spiritual truth even over “womanly” responsibilities like serving guests in one’s home (Luke 10:38).

-Although men in J esus’ day normally would not allow women to count change into their hands for fear of physical contact, J esus touched women to heal them and allowed women to touch Him (Luke 13:10ff.; Mark 5:25ff.).

-J esus even allowed a small group of women to travel with Him and His disciples (Luke 8:1– 3), an unprecedented happening at that time.

-After His resurrection, J esus appeared first to Mary Magdalene and sent her to announce His resurrection to the disciples (J ohn 20:1– 18), despite the fact that women were not allowed to be witnesses in J ewish courts because they were considered liars.

The Church and women

-From the very beginning, women fulfilled a vital role in the Christian church (Acts 1:12– 14; 9:36– 42; 16:13– 15; 17:1– 4, 10– 12; 18:1– 2, 18, 24– 28; Rom. 16; 1 Cor. 16:19; 2 Tim. 1:5; 4:19), but not one of leadership.

-The apostles were all men; the chief missionary activity was done by men; the writing of the New Testament was the work of men; and leadership in the churches was entrusted to men.

-Although the Apostle Paul respected women and worked side by side with them for the furtherance of the gospel (Rom. 16; Phil. 4:3), he appointed no female elders or pastors.

-In his letters, he urged that men were to be the leaders in the church and that women were not to teach or exercise authority over men (1 Tim. 2:12).

-Therefore, although women are spiritual equals with men and the ministry of women is essential to the body of Christ, women are excluded from leadership over men in the church.

-Men and women stand as equals before God, both bearing the image of God Himself.

-However, without making one inferior to the other, God calls upon both men and women to fulfill the roles and responsibilities specifically designed for them, a pattern that can be seen even in the Godhead (1 Cor. 11:3).

-In fulfilling the divinely given roles taught in the New Testament, women are able to realize their full potential because they are following the plan of their own Creator and Designer.

-Only in obedience to Him and His design will women truly be able, in the fullest sense, to give glory to God.

CHRISTIANITY AND ENVIRONMENT CONSERVATION

-The Bible calls Christians to be the stewards of the earth. We are called to maintain and protect the earth.

-God loved His creation.

- He protected and maintained His creation.

-We are created in the image of God and as Christians we should love the earth. Genesis 1:26(NIV) says "Then God said, 'Let us make man in our image, in our likeness, and let them rule over the fish of the sea and the birds of the air, over the livestock, over all the earth, and over all the creatures that move along the ground'.

- God did not give us earth to man so man could consume all the resources over all the earth. We have to make a suitable environment for all of God's creatures.

-Christians are called and can change the earth through awareness, conservation, pollution control and environmental restoration.

-Christians have to take the lead in creating awareness of the earth's environmental problems. Rev. Tom Wenig, pastor of Lutheran Church of Our Redeemer, says that "[environmental awareness] is really trying to develop a mind-set. ... It isn't trying to take on a big political agenda."

-First, the church has to realize that they are called by God to sustain and protect their

environment called earth. For decades, Christians have ignored this issue.

- The church should freely share the importance of conserving resources, recycling, donating, and other ideas to preserve our environment.

- The church should also reach out to non-Christians and make them aware of the importance of taking care of our earth.

- Christians and churches are just beginning to work together to help make positive and meaningful changes to our world.

- The hope is that this trend continues and a national and global support continues to grow toward the awareness.

- Christians can have a positive impact on plants and animals through conservation. Psalm 145:9-10 says "The Lord is good to all; he has compassion on all he has made.

- All you have made will praise you, o Lord; your saints will extol you." We can conserve energy by turning things off and not using them and turning down the thermostat at home.

- Controlling pollution as individuals and Christians will benefit and preserve the environment.